

Beyond Encampment? Understanding Attitudes Toward Refugee Integration

Mae MacDonald* Adam Lichtenheld†

August 7, 2026

Word count: 10,119

Abstract

Most of the world's refugees live in low- and middle-income countries, where debates center on integrating those already present rather than admitting new arrivals. Yet existing research focuses largely on admission in high-income countries. We provide one of the first nationwide assessments of attitudes toward integration in the Global South, drawing on a survey of 3,326 Kenyans fielded after a reform was passed but before implementation, with embedded experiments varying policy dimension and refugee group. Support for integration is high, but citizens are less supportive of allowing refugees to leave camps than granting economic inclusion or creating integrated settlements, and support varies significantly by refugee nationality. Opposition is driven primarily by fears of crime, terrorism, and the spread of conflict. Ethnic kinship and close contact predict support, while economic factors matter little. These findings suggest that integration is politically feasible, but insecurity associated with free movement remains the largest concern.

*Department of Political Science and Immigration Policy Lab, Stanford University. Email: maemac@stanford.edu

†Institute of Security and Global Affairs, Leiden University. E-mail: a.g.lichtenheld@fgga.leidenuniv.nl.

We are grateful to Jeremy Weinstein, Jens Hainmueller, Sigrid Weber, Hans Leuders, Paige Hill, and Jocelyn Perry for thoughtful feedback, as well as participants in multiple Immigration Policy Lab workshops, the UNHCR–World Bank Joint Data Center 3rd Research Conference on Forced Displacement, and our 2024 International Studies Association (ISA) panel. For valuable conversations in the early stages of this research, we thank Allan Mukuki and Marie Iradukunda (Strathmore Law School), Philip Ogonda (Refugee Consortium of Kenya), and colleagues at the Refugee-Led Research Hub, along with the many individuals who generously shared their perspectives during exploratory fieldwork. We thank Mary Achieng, Michael Mwarange, Maggie Ileri, Riccardo Ochieng, and the team at TIFA Research for outstanding work implementing the survey. Thanks, also, to Masud Rahman in the UNHCR Kenya office for providing helpful administrative data, and to Caroline Robbins and Toros Pinar for research assistance. This project was supported by funding from the Stanford King Center on Global Development and the Freeman Spogli Institute for International Studies.

1 Introduction

In high-income countries (HICs), debates over refugee policy generally center on whether refugees should be admitted. Once admitted, refugees typically receive rights to work, move, and access public services. But in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs), which host 71% of the world’s refugees, the central question is often not admission but integration. In many cases, refugees are permitted to enter but are restricted from working, accessing services, or living outside designated camps.¹ These restrictions can leave refugees dependent on humanitarian assistance by limiting their ability to earn income and meet their own needs. As displacement becomes more protracted and humanitarian funding declines, international organizations have increasingly promoted integration reforms to strengthen refugee self-reliance and reduce long-term dependence on aid (International Development Association, 2020).

This shift is reflected in the growing number of LMICs, including Colombia, Ethiopia, Jordan, Kenya, Thailand, and Uganda, that have adopted policies expanding refugees’ rights to employment, movement, and access to services (De Haas, Natter and Vezzoli, 2018; Blair, Grossman and Weinstein, 2022). Yet integration also has important implications for host citizens that could lead to backlash. Allowing refugees to leave camps and participate more fully in national economies and communities may heighten concerns about insecurity, social tension, job competition, and public services. Given that refugee arrivals have sometimes imposed costs on host communities and generated electoral backlash, integration reforms may carry political risks for governments that pursue them (Hangartner et al., 2019; Steinmayr, 2016; Roza and Vargas, 2021).

Despite the growing importance of refugee integration reforms, we know little about whether citizens in major LMIC host countries support them. Existing research focuses overwhelmingly on refugee admission or presence in HICs (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2014; Weber et al., 2025). The smaller LMIC literature examines attitudes toward hosting, naturalization, deportation, and proximity to refugee populations, but rarely asks citizens what rights refugees should receive or whether they should be allowed to leave camps.² This omission matters because integration differs from hosting. Citizens may accept refugees’ presence while opposing their access to the same labor markets, neighborhoods, and services as citizens. Support may also vary across the specific rights granted, the refugee group receiving them, and citizens’ own relationships with refugees.

¹One in five refugees lives in a camp-like setting, and three-quarters of encamped refugees are in sub-Saharan Africa (Anti et al., 2025).

²The LMIC literature is concentrated in the Middle East (Alrababa’h et al., 2021; Ghosn, Braithwaite and Chu, 2019; Getmansky, Sinmazdemir and Zeitsoff, 2018). Research in Africa has examined naturalization and deportation preferences (Cogley, Doces and Whitaker, 2019), geographical proximity (Zhou, 2024; Betts et al., 2023), and attitudes towards refugee arrivals (Aksoy, Ginn and Malpassi, 2024). An important exception outside Africa is Allen, Ruiz and Vargas-Silva (2024)’s study of migration policy preferences in Colombia.

We examine these questions in Kenya, a major refugee-hosting country that has historically confined most refugees to camps and restricted their access to formal employment and movement. Kenya’s 2021 Refugees Act introduced reforms in three areas: economic inclusion, freedom of movement, and integrated settlements in which refugees and nearby citizens live together and share services. We fielded a survey after the Act had passed but before it was implemented or widely politicized. Fewer than 2% of respondents could accurately describe its provisions. This setting allows us to measure attitudes toward a real and imminent reform before citizens’ views were strongly shaped by partisan debate or misinformation.

Our evidence comes from a phone survey of 3,326 Kenyan citizens. The sample includes 2,510 respondents from a nationally representative survey and an oversample of residents near the Dadaab and Kakuma refugee camps. The survey contains two independently randomized experiments. The first varies the dimension of integration presented to respondents: work rights and economic inclusion, freedom of movement, or integrated settlements and shared services. The second varies the refugee group referenced: refugees in general, Somali refugees, or South Sudanese refugees. We combine these experiments with measures of broader policy preferences; respondent characteristics; perceived economic, security, and cultural effects; and coded open-ended explanations of support and opposition.

Our study yields three key findings. First, public support for refugee integration is relatively high, but not everyone who supports hosting also supports integration. When asked to choose among alternative refugee policies, 43.1% select full integration, making it the most popular option. This remains lower than the 64.7% who support Kenya hosting refugees generally, while 12.3% prefer that refugees remain in camps. Thus, although support for hosting and integration is widespread and closely correlated, a meaningful minority supports hosting refugees without granting them full integration.

Second, the main dividing line is whether refugees should be allowed to leave the camps, with opposition driven primarily by security concerns. Large majorities support granting refugees work rights and economic inclusion (69%) and converting camps into integrated settlements where refugees and nearby citizens share services (73%); support for these policies is statistically indistinguishable. By contrast, support for freedom of movement is significantly lower, at 60%. Respondents explain their opposition largely in terms of crime, terrorism, and fears that refugees will bring conflicts from their home countries into Kenya. These same concerns shape attitudes toward particular refugee groups: support for integration falls almost by half when respondents are asked about Somali refugees – who are strongly associated with insecurity – rather than refugees in general.

Economic considerations matter less than expected. Support is high for economic inclusion, the policy that would most directly expose citizens to labor market competition. Measures of personal economic vulnerability, including income, unemployment, employment formality, and agricultural work, do not consistently predict support for integration. Citizens who are pessimistic about the national economy (sociotropic concerns) are somewhat less supportive of integration, but these associations are modest and inconsistent. Respondents also identify economic benefits from integration, including business growth, job creation, tax revenue, and donor-financed services. Economic considerations are therefore salient, but they cut in both

directions and do not appear to be the principal source of opposition.

Third, many of the same factors predict support for both refugee hosting and integration. Ethnic kinship and close personal contact with refugees are the strongest predictors of favorable attitudes toward both outcomes. Naming Somali refugees sharply reduces support for both hosting and integration among the wider population, while Kenyan Somali respondents are substantially more supportive of hosting and integrating their ethnic kin. Contrary to our expectations, citizens' personal economic circumstances predict neither hosting nor integration, even among people most exposed to labor market competition from integration.

This paper makes three contributions. First, it shifts the study of refugee attitudes from admission to integration. Existing research focuses mainly on whether citizens support admitting or hosting refugees, while work on integration has largely examined employment rights (Allen, Ruiz and Vargas-Silva, 2024). To our knowledge, this is the first nationally representative study of attitudes toward refugee integration in sub-Saharan Africa, the region hosting the most refugees in protracted situations (UNHCR, 2026*a*). We show that integration comprises distinct rights that activate different concerns. Citizens are not uniformly more opposed to integration than to hosting. Their resistance is concentrated on freedom of movement, the dimension that refugee encampment is designed to prevent.

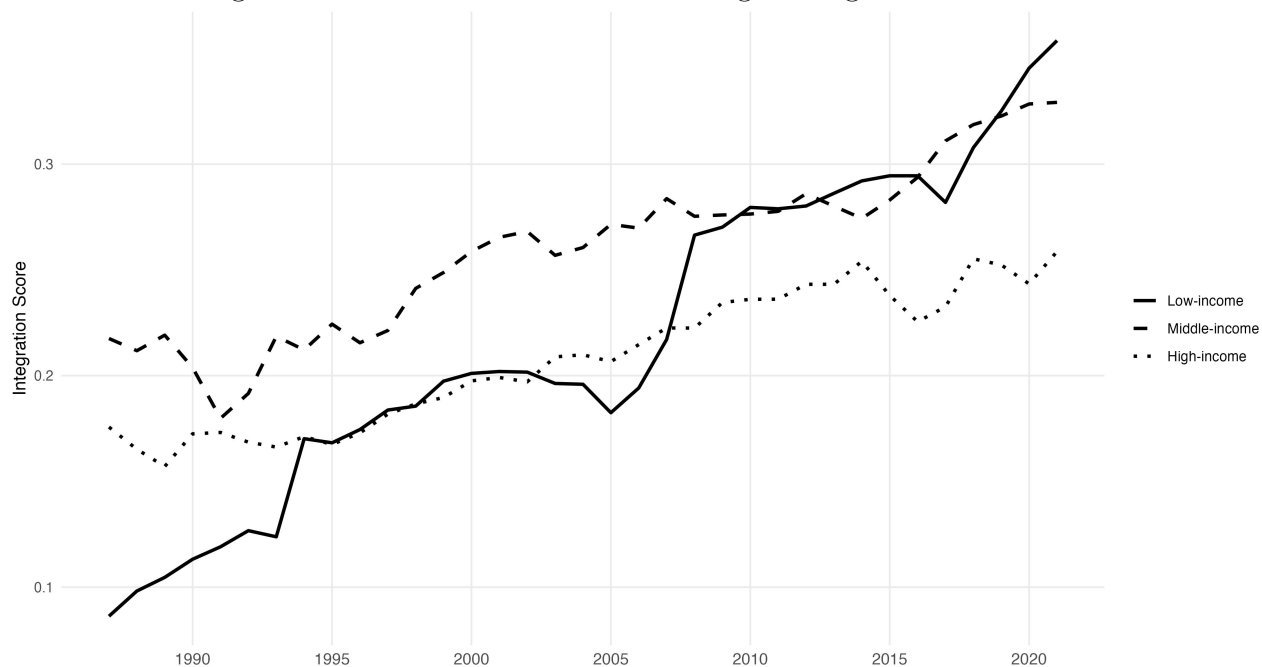
Second, we identify which explanations for public attitudes toward refugees travel to integration in LMICs. As in HICs, cultural proximity and close contact increase support, while personal economic vulnerability matters little (Weber et al., 2025). However, security concerns outweigh economic competition, echoing evidence from Turkey (Turkoglu, 2026). Respondents also recognize refugees' economic contributions and frequently invoke humanitarian obligations, shared regional identity, and the possibility that Kenyans could themselves become displaced, consistent with findings from Jordan (Alrababa'h et al., 2021).

Third, the findings speak to the political viability of integration reforms. LMIC governments and international organizations increasingly promote integration and self-reliance (Miliband, 2019; UNHCR, 2025*a*), and public opposition may be less extensive than often assumed. Employment rights and service access appear more politically acceptable when refugees remain in established hosting areas, while freedom of movement faces greater resistance, especially for groups associated with insecurity. The success of integration reforms may therefore depend more on addressing security concerns than on countering fears of economic competition.

2 The Rise of “Local Integration” Policies

UNHCR and other international actors have increasingly encouraged asylum countries to enable the “local integration” of refugees into host communities (UNHCR, 2019; Hovil, 2014; Crisp, 2004; Oliver and Boyle, 2019). One of the core objectives of the 2018 Global Compact on Refugees (GCR), affirmed by the United Nations General Assembly, is to “enhance self-reliance” through decent work and free movement of refugees (UNHCR, 2021). UNHCR has also increasingly discouraged encampment and enacted policies that treat refugee camps as a last resort (UNHCR, 2009, 2014).

Figure 1: Global Liberalization of Refugee Integration Policies



Note: Integration Score uses mean employment strand and scaled free movement measure from the Dataset of World Refugee and Asylum Policies (Blair, Grossman and Weinstein, 2022). Uses World Bank classifications of countries based on annual income levels.

These shifts come in response to two intersecting trends: rising numbers of displaced people and declining humanitarian assistance. Over the past two decades, the global refugee population has nearly tripled (UNHCR, 2024). In 2025, 70 percent of this population lived in a protracted situation without expectation of repatriation or resettlement to a third country (UNHCR, 2026a). At the same time, resources to sustain refugees have contracted: UNHCR’s 2024 budget (\$10.8 billion) was only 48% funded (UNHCR, 2025a). This worsened in 2025 with U.S. and European foreign aid cuts (UNHCR, 2025c). These pressures are most acute in sub-Saharan Africa, which hosts more refugees in protracted situations, maintains more refugee camps, and receives more UNHCR aid than any other region (see Appendix).

Consistent with the GCR, local integration policies seek to foster self-reliance by enabling movement out of camps, providing access to labor markets and public services (e.g., health and education), and granting pathways to naturalization. In doing so, they aim to reduce dependence on international aid. As shown in Fig. 1, low-income countries have made some of the most significant legislative strides on integration through expanding rights to employment and movement.

3 Theory

What drives public support for or opposition to refugee integration? We begin with the broader literature on attitudes toward refugee admission and hosting, mostly developed in HICs, then consider how its findings apply to integration in LMICs. Existing research emphasizes economic and cultural concerns, with a smaller literature on perceived security threats.

3.1 Existing Research on Attitudes toward Refugees

3.1.1 Economic Concerns

Attitudes toward refugees are shaped partly by their perceived economic effects on host communities. Refugees can benefit host economies by supplying labor, increasing demand, paying taxes, and reducing aid dependence (Clemens, Huang and Graham, 2018; Legrain, 2016; Bahar and Dooley, 2019). These aggregate gains may nevertheless impose concentrated costs on low-skilled, informal, female, or agricultural workers (Ceritoglu et al., 2017; Verme and Schuettler, 2021; Lebow, 2022; Aksu, Erzan and Kirdar, 2022; Del Carpio and Wagner, 2015; Sakamoto, Ullah and Tani, 2024).

Public opinion depends less on these actual effects than on how citizens perceive refugees' impact on the national economy and on their own livelihoods. Existing research finds that sociotropic concerns matter more than egocentric ones: citizens favor refugees viewed as skilled or economically productive and oppose those perceived as burdens, largely regardless of their own economic circumstances (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2014; Weber et al., 2025; Adida, Lo and Platas, 2019; Bansak, Hainmueller and Hangartner, 2016, 2023; Hainmueller and Hiscox, 2010; Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; Valentino et al., 2019). Citizens may also worry about pressure on housing and public services (Jeannet, Heidland and Ruhs, 2021; Allen et al., 2024; Allen, Ruiz and Silva, 2022; Balkan et al., 2018; Dagnelie, Mayda and Maystadt, 2023). In many LMICs, however, humanitarian funding provides schools, clinics, roads, and employment in refugee-hosting areas, allowing nearby communities to benefit from refugee presence, which increases support (Zhou, Grossman and Ge, 2023; Alix-Garcia et al., 2018; Sanghi, Onder and Vemuru, 2016).

3.1.2 Cultural Proximity and Contact

Perceived cultural threat can shape attitudes toward refugees as strongly as, or more strongly than, economic concerns (Adida, Lo and Platas, 2019; Bansak, Hainmueller and Hangartner, 2016; Alrababa'h et al., 2021; Weber et al., 2025). Across contexts, citizens are more supportive of refugee groups viewed as culturally similar or less threatening (Card, Dustmann and Preston, 2012; Adida, Lo and Platas, 2019; Adida, Laitin and Valfort, 2016; Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2014; Alrababa'h et al., 2021; Bansak, Hainmueller and Hangartner, 2016, 2023). In Africa, cultural proximity often takes the form of ethnic kinship across borders. Such ties can encourage more accommodating policies and improve refugees' access to employment, housing, and services (Gale, 2006; Porter et al., 2008; Fisk, 2019). For example, Blair, Grossman and Weinstein (2022) find that governments are more likely to liberalize refugee policy

when political elites share ethnic ties with populations facing persecution across the border.

Attitudes also depend on the form of exposure citizens have to refugees. Meaningful interpersonal contact can reduce prejudice and improve attitudes (Allport, 1954; Ghosn, Braithwaite and Chu, 2019; Alrababa'h et al., 2021; Campo et al., 2023), whereas geographic proximity without sustained interaction may provoke backlash, particularly during economic stress or large inflows (Hangartner et al., 2019; Roza and Vargas, 2021). Evidence from sub-Saharan Africa is mixed: Zhou (2024) links proximity to more restrictive attitudes, while Betts et al. (2023) finds no such relationship in Kenya.

3.1.3 Security Concerns

Security has received less attention than economic or cultural explanations, despite a long-standing debate over whether refugees and refugee camps contribute to conflict in host countries (Salehyan and Gleditsch, 2006; Zhou and Shaver, 2021; Savun and Gineste, 2019). Existing evidence suggests that perceived security threats can worsen public attitudes. Terrorist attacks reduce support for refugees and migrants in Europe (Legewie, 2013; Böhmelt, Bove and Nussio, 2020), while in Turkey, priming Syrian refugees' ties to militant groups increased threat perceptions among the ethnic majority but not among Kurdish respondents with ethnic ties to some refugees (Getmansky, Sinmazdemir and Zeitzoff, 2018). Similarly, Turkoglu (2026) finds greater hostility toward refugees from regions linked to rebel groups, though this may reflect pre-existing intergroup antagonism as much as perceived security risk.

3.2 Theoretical Implications For Refugee Integration

Existing research suggests that attitudes toward refugees are shaped primarily by sociotropic economic assessments and cultural proximity. Yet this evidence comes overwhelmingly from HICs and focuses on the admission or presence of refugees rather than their integration. Whether these explanations travel to LMICs – where most refugees live, and where the central policy question is the incorporation of refugees already present – remains an open question.

There are two reasons we may expect attitudes towards refugee admission or hosting in HICs to differ from integration in LMICs. First, the economic and security context differs. Many LMICs have high poverty and unemployment, large informal labor markets, and weak social protection, making employment especially precarious. At the same time, limited welfare provision may make refugees less likely to be seen primarily as burdens on the state. Many refugees already participate in agriculture, casual labor, and small businesses, and refugee-hosting areas often benefit from humanitarian assistance. With respect to security, LMIC host countries are frequently close to the conflicts refugees have fled, which makes citizens more aware of the violence refugees escaped and the humanitarian case for protecting them, but also the risk that conflict could spread across the border.

Second, the relationship between refugees and citizens is different. Integration in LMICs typically concerns populations that have lived in the host country for decades rather than

prospective arrivals. Citizens may know refugees personally, trade or work with them, speak the same languages, share ethnic ties across borders, or benefit from aid and services concentrated in hosting areas. At the same time, established refugee groups may already be politicized and blamed for economic hardship or insecurity. Extending further rights to a familiar but marginalized population is therefore a different proposition that may generate different reactions compared to admitting a new group.

For these reasons, the factors that drive public attitudes toward refugee hosting in HICs may operate differently when citizens evaluate integration in LMICs. Integration also redistributes the costs and benefits of hosting. Under encampment, these are concentrated among communities living near camps or working in particular sectors. Integration disperses these consequences across a broader population that may face economic competition or see refugees settle nearby. Accordingly, we examine how support varies across the type of integration policy, the refugee group concerned, and citizens' own characteristics and relationships with refugees.

3.3 Integration Policy Type

Integration in LMICs involves three main policy dimensions: economic inclusion, freedom of movement, and shared access to services. These correspond to the core commitments of the Global Compact's self-reliance agenda and to the three pillars of Kenya's 2021 Refugees Act. They differ, however, in the forms of incorporation they entail and the concerns they are likely to activate.

Economic Inclusion. Easing work restrictions and expanding refugees' access to permits, financial services, and professional accreditation may heighten fears of job competition. Because many refugees already work informally without permits in casual labor, agriculture, and small enterprises, egocentric concerns may be strongest among formal-sector workers competing for salaried and professional positions. However, integration policies may also expand access to banking, credit, and business services beyond formal work rights, potentially intensifying competition concerns among non-salaried workers in contexts of high unemployment and economic precarity. Consistent with this possibility, Bousquet et al. (2025) find greater hostility toward refugees among Ugandan and Ethiopian respondents who share their occupations, including informal work such as farming and cleaning.

Sociotropic concerns may also reduce support. Citizens who are pessimistic about the national economy may fear that refugee inclusion will increase unemployment. These perceptions may persist despite evidence from other regions that expanding work rights has negligible or positive effects on local workers.³

³In Colombia, expanding work rights for Venezuelan migrants improved their well-being with negligible labor-market consequences for locals (Ibáñez et al., 2025; Bahar, Cowgill and Guzman, 2022), and studies find similar results from lifting work restrictions in Europe (Marbach, Hainmueller and Hangartner, 2018; Ahrens et al., 2023). Formalizing refugee employment may also benefit informal workers by encouraging movement into formal jobs and raising informal wages (Gülek, 2024). More broadly, economic inclusion can stimulate local economies through business creation, trade, and increased demand for goods and services

Freedom of Movement. In camp-based settings,⁴ freedom of movement could have broad economic, cultural, and security implications. Camps are typically located far from major cities and near the borders of refugees’ home country (Anti et al., 2025), meaning encamped refugees are geographically separated from most citizens. In many cases, refugees may leave only with special permission and for limited purposes. Allowing them to relocate to towns, cities, and more fertile rural areas would bring them into closer contact – and greater competition – with communities that have had little prior exposure to them. This may heighten concerns about job competition in more prosperous labor markets, access to agricultural land, cultural change and social tension, and potential for conflict, particularly where refugee groups are associated with armed actors or wars in their origin countries.

Shared Services and “Integrated Settlements.” Integration policies often allow refugees and local residents to share services, but this can take two forms. In HICs, integration typically extends refugees’ access to government services, potentially generating opposition if locals perceive greater competition for scarce public resources (Getmansky, Simmazdemir and Zeitzoff, 2018). In LMICs, by contrast, local residents may gain access to donor-funded services provided by humanitarian organizations whose presence is largely tied to the refugee population (Jansen and de Bruijne, 2020; Zhou, Grossman and Ge, 2023; Alix-Garcia et al., 2018). Uganda’s “integrated settlement” model is the most prominent example of this: refugees and host citizens live alongside one another without strict camp borders and share primarily donor-funded healthcare and education services, supplemented by government provision. By bringing tangible benefits to nearby communities, such policies may improve attitudes toward refugees (Zhou et al., 2025). They may also raise fewer concerns about movement because refugees remain locally concentrated and do not necessarily gain greater access to employment, although this may generate other forms of opposition among people living next to the camps.

These differences suggest that citizens should be more supportive of integrated settlements than of either economic inclusion or freedom of movement. Integrated settlements can deliver visible benefits to host communities while keeping refugees concentrated in established hosting areas, and may therefore generate fewer concerns about labor-market competition, cultural change, or insecurity.

H1: *Citizens express greater support for integrated settlements than for economic inclusion or freedom of movement.*

3.4 Refugee Group

Public support for admitting refugees varies across groups. Citizens tend to favor refugees seen as posing fewer economic or security threats, as culturally closer, or as having greater humanitarian need (Bansak, Hainmueller and Hangartner, 2023; Weber et al., 2025). Group

(Groeger, León-Ciliotta and Stillman, 2024; Del Carpio and Wagner, 2015; Maystadt and Duranton, 2019; Verme and Schuettler, 2021).

⁴Globally, one in five refugees lives in camps, and three-quarters of encamped refugees live in sub-Saharan Africa (Anti et al., 2025).

distinctions may be especially important for integration, which often concerns groups that have lived in the host country for years and are already associated with particular histories of contact, cooperation, politicization, or insecurity.

We therefore expect support for integration to vary by refugee group. Citizens should be less willing to extend rights to groups perceived as culturally distant or as having negative economic or security effects, whether these perceptions arise from direct experience or from elite- and media-driven political narratives.

H2: *Citizens express lower support for integrating refugee groups perceived as having negative effects on their country.*

3.5 Citizen Characteristics

In addition to the policy dimension and refugee group, support for refugee integration may also depend on the characteristics of citizens. While existing research has shown that citizens' attitudes seem to be driven less by their own circumstances and more by the profile of refugees (Weber et al., 2025), these patterns may differ in LMICs, where unemployment, poverty, and informal employment are more widespread, and where citizens are more likely to share ethnic or personal ties to refugees.

Economic Exposure. Economic concerns may shape support through both personal vulnerability and perceptions of the national economy. Formal-sector workers may be especially concerned about extending work rights, which could increase competition for salaried and professional positions. Informal and agricultural workers may be more sensitive to freedom of movement, which could bring refugees into local labor markets and areas where they already work. More broadly, citizens with low incomes, limited education, or insecure employment may fear greater competition resulting from refugees' economic inclusion or mobility. Urban residents may also oppose freedom of movement if they expect it to draw more refugees into cities, increase pressure on housing and services, or heighten security concerns. Support may further depend on sociotropic concerns: citizens may oppose integration because they fear that it will worsen existing economic problems in the country, such as high unemployment, even when they do not expect to be personally affected (Weber et al., 2025). This leads to the following hypotheses:

H3: *Economically vulnerable citizens are less likely to support refugee integration, especially economic inclusion.*

H4: *Citizens concerned about the national economy are less likely to support refugee integration, especially economic inclusion.*

Cultural and Social Proximity. Citizens who are culturally or socially closer to refugees may be less likely to view their integration as threatening. Proximity may ease concerns about cultural change and weaken the stereotypes underlying economic or security fears. In

LMICs, proximity may take two forms. First, citizens may share ethnic ties with refugee groups, especially in Africa, where ethnic communities often extend across national borders. We expect citizens to be particularly supportive of integrating refugees with whom they share ethnic kinship. Second, citizens may have close personal relationships with refugees. Because integration concerns populations that already live in the host country, many citizens – particularly in refugee-hosting areas – know refugees as their friends, relatives, and neighbors. Citizens with close contact with refugees may perceive them as less threatening and express greater support for their integration. This leads to the following hypotheses:

H5: *Citizens who share ethnic ties with a refugee group are more likely to support integration, especially of their ethnic kin.*

H6: *Citizens with close contact with refugees are more likely to support refugee integration.*

4 Context

4.1 Refugee Integration in Kenya

Before 2021, refugees in Kenya were governed by the 2006 Refugees Act and a 2014 encampment policy, which together confined refugees to designated camps, tightly restricted work permits, and allowed movement only with short-term passes.⁵ In 2021, the Kenyan Parliament passed a new Refugees Act that addressed three main dimensions of integration: economic inclusion, freedom of movement, and integrated settlements (Halakhe and Omondi, 2024; Leghtas and Kitenge, 2022). The reform, which later became known as the “Shirika Plan,” followed the adoption of the Global Compact on Refugees and the World Bank’s pledge to support policies expanding refugee rights.⁶

First, the Act sought to promote economic inclusion by expanding access to work permits, professional certification, and formal financial services, including bank accounts, credit, and mobile money. Although refugees could previously obtain work permits in principle, permits were rarely issued, and restrictions on financial services excluded most refugees from the formal economy (Venui and Iragi, 2023).⁷ Many refugees nevertheless worked informally. In and around the camps, they owned or worked for businesses, performed casual labor, and served as “incentive workers” for international organizations (Betts, Omata and Sterck,

⁵Kenya initially welcomed refugees during the postcolonial period, but its policies became more restrictive following large-scale arrivals in the 1990s (Jaji, 2022).

⁶International donors committed nearly \$200 million to the Shirika Plan, while a \$1.2 billion loan was made contingent on implementation of the Act and related reforms (Nyamori, 2024; Nasubo and Muon, 2024). The Act also contained restrictive provisions unrelated to integration and was criticized for its top-down design (Nyamori, 2024; Opanda, 2025).

⁷An exception was the Kalobeyei settlement; see Betts, Omata and Sterck (2020).

2018; Alix-Garcia et al., 2018; de la Chaux and Haugh, 2020; Jansen and de Bruijne, 2020; Teferra, 2022; Muhumad and Jaji, 2023; Betts et al., 2024). Refugees living in cities also participated extensively in the informal economy, particularly through microenterprises.

Second, the Act sought to expand freedom of movement. It allowed refugees to move within “designated areas” and created pathways for refugees from East African Community countries to obtain EAC citizenship and live outside camps. Although the scope of these provisions were unclear, they represented a potentially significant departure from Kenya’s encampment policy. Since 2014, refugees had generally been required to live in designated camps and could leave only with short-term movement passes for purposes such as healthcare, education, or business (Betts, Omata and Sterck, 2018). Consequently, 86.4% of registered refugees were based in Kakuma or Dadaab, Kenya’s two refugee camps (UNHCR, 2025*b*). Although some refugees lived in Nairobi, Mombasa, and other cities, urban registration was difficult to obtain. The encampment policy followed a series of attacks by Al-Shabaab, an Islamist militant group based in Somalia, which the government alleged involved refugees from Dadaab.

Third, the Act proposed transforming refugee camps into “integrated settlements,” in which refugees and members of surrounding host communities would live alongside one another and share services provided by international organizations. Prior to the Act, camps were formally separated from neighboring communities. In practice, however, nearby Kenyans frequently entered the camps to access aid-funded schools and healthcare facilities, seek employment with NGOs or in refugee households, and sell goods such as charcoal and firewood (Betts, Omata and Sterck, 2018; Nasubo and Muon, 2024; MacDonald, 2026). Host-community members often relied on these donor-funded services because government provision in surrounding areas was limited. Around Kakuma, for example, 69% of Turkana hosts had no formal education, compared with 47% of refugees, while host-community members accounted for an estimated 10–15% of camp healthcare users (World Bank and UNHCR, 2021). The Act would therefore remove the formal barriers separating camps from neighboring communities, allowing refugees and hosts to live in the same area and access shared services.

The 2021 Refugees Act took effect in 2022, and the government issued implementing regulations in 2024 before officially launching the Shirika Plan in March 2025. Our survey, fielded in 2023, examined all three dimensions of the new integration policy as they were understood at the time.⁸

4.2 Refugees in Kenya

At the time of our survey, Kenya hosted 654,147 registered refugees and asylum-seekers from more than 20 countries. Somalis (51%) and South Sudanese (26%) made up more than three-quarters of Kenya’s refugee population, so we focus on these two groups. The

⁸After the 2023 survey, implementation priorities shifted. Broad freedom of movement did not materialize, economic reforms remained limited, and early integrated-settlement efforts focused on municipalizing camp areas and transferring healthcare provision to the government.

remaining population came primarily from the Democratic Republic of Congo, Ethiopia, Burundi, and Sudan (United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, 2023).

Somali refugees are often associated with insecurity in Kenya (Otunnu, 1992; Murunga, 2009; Shahow, 2021; Sheikh, 2021). Al-Shabaab has carried out several high-profile attacks in the country, and the government has linked some of them to Somali refugees, contributing to raids, detentions, and forced relocations targeting Somali communities (Amnesty International, 2014; Simpson and Lapar, 2013; Betts et al., 2024). Somali refugees are also religiously distinct from most Kenyans, being predominantly Muslim in contrast to Kenya’s Christian majority. Economically, however, they are relatively prosperous, participate extensively in commercial networks, and are often seen as contributing to trade (Muhumad and Jaji, 2023; Betts et al., 2024). They also share ethnic ties with Kenyan Somalis, who comprise approximately 7% of Kenya’s population. These ties facilitate access to employment, housing, and business networks (Campbell, 2006; Carrier, 2016; Betts et al., 2024).

South Sudanese refugees present a different profile, raising fewer security and cultural concerns but potentially greater economic ones. They are not associated with terrorism, and Kenya has historically been sympathetic to their cause, tacitly supporting the Sudan People’s Liberation Army in the 1990s (Abdelaaty, 2021; RCK, 2024). Many South Sudanese are Christian and belong to Nilotic ethnolinguistic groups with cultural ties to several Kenyan communities, including the Turkana who host refugees around Kakuma. Economically, however, South Sudanese refugees are among the poorest refugee groups in Kenya, with low employment and high food insecurity (Sanghi, Onder and Vemuru, 2016; Alix-Garcia et al., 2018; Teferra, 2022; Betts et al., 2024). They may therefore be perceived as competitors for low-wage work or as a burden on public resources.

The two groups therefore evoke different combinations of economic, cultural, and security concerns. Somalis are often perceived as posing greater security and cultural threats, and many Kenyans view their overall impact on the country negatively, largely because of their perceived association with attacks carried out by Al-Shabaab. At the same time, they are associated with economic contributions and share ethnic kinship ties with part of the Kenyan population. South Sudanese refugees generate fewer security and cultural concerns but are seen as contributing less economically and may be perceived as competitors for jobs and public resources. Integration therefore carries different implications for each group. For Somalis, freedom of movement and formal economic inclusion could build on existing commercial and kinship networks while intensifying security and cultural concerns. For South Sudanese, integration could expand access to work and services while raising concerns about economic competition. If security and cultural considerations weigh more heavily than economic ones, we expect citizens to favor integrating South Sudanese refugees over Somalis.

5 Research Design

To understand attitudes toward refugee integration, we fielded a nationwide phone survey in Kenya from September to October 2023, after the 2021 Refugee Act had been passed but before it was implemented. A total of 3,326 people completed the survey, comprising a

nationally representative sample of 2,510 respondents and an oversample of 816 respondents from the sub-counties surrounding Dadaab and Kakuma camps (404 in Garissa and 412 in Turkana).⁹ To improve representativeness, we constructed post-stratification weights using entropy balancing, matching our sample to the 2023 Afrobarometer survey (Hainmueller, 2012). Unless otherwise noted, all analyses use these weights (normalized to mean 1 in-sample) and HC1 robust standard errors.

Studying attitudes toward a real policy before implementation offers two advantages.¹⁰ First, specific, real-world policies tend to elicit more valid responses than abstract or hypothetical scenarios (Vlaev, 2012; Kaderabek, 2022). Second, once a reform becomes contested by politicians and media, citizens’ stated attitudes increasingly reflect partisan and elite cues rather than considered evaluations of the policy itself. The Shirika Plan became politicized after our survey, including through false claims that it would grant refugees citizenship and voting rights (Capital FM News, 2024; Nation Media Group, 2025). Our survey therefore provides a relatively uncontaminated measure of baseline support: fewer than 2 percent of respondents could accurately describe the Act’s provisions.

Our research design combines two survey experiments with descriptive and qualitative data. Both experiments were pre-registered along with their corresponding hypotheses, with the treatments reflecting the policies and groups central to Kenya’s integration reforms. The first experiment varies the dimension of integration policy under consideration while the other varies the refugee group. We interpret the joint pattern across the experiments alongside descriptive and open-ended questions, as well as measures of respondent characteristics. The study was developed in consultation with local stakeholders, including UNHCR, NGOs, legal experts, and refugee-led organizations, and builds on eight months of fieldwork and key informant interviews.

5.1 Survey Experiments

Our first experiment tests whether support for integration varies by policy type (H1). We first asked respondents whether they had heard of the new refugee law and, if so, what they knew about it. Respondents were then randomly assigned with equal probability to a control group, which received no information about the Act, or to one of three treatment groups – economic inclusion, free movement, or integrated settlements (shared services) – each of which received a brief factual summary of one dimension of the Act (see Table 1). Respondents in the treatment groups then rated their support for the policy on a five-

⁹Because the nationally representative sample itself contains 78 respondents in Turkana or Garissa, the full sample includes 894 camp-county respondents in total. Analyses that condition on residence near a camp use that figure; see the Appendix.

¹⁰Our pre-analysis plan (PAP) envisioned a two-wave panel: a baseline before implementation and a follow-up tracking attitude change afterwards. Because implementation of the 2021 Act was slow, we fielded only the baseline, and the results reported here are cross-sectional. A separate national survey fielded in February 2026 repeated several items from the baseline. Because the two waves are independent samples, we report that comparison in the Appendix.

point scale. We conduct robustness checks in the appendix that exclude respondents who had previously heard of the new refugee law (1.3%) and who failed a comprehension check (12.2%).

Since the control group received no information about the Act, our primary comparison is across the three policy dimensions rather than between each treatment and the control group. We separately test whether information about a specific policy dimension affects broader attitudes toward refugees, comparing each treatment group with the control group on two measures of support for integration described below: preference for integration, from the five-option policy menu, and support for Kenya hosting refugees, from the generic arm of the nationality experiment).

Table 1: Policy experiment: treatment prompts

Arm	Prompt
Economic inclusion	<i>One of the proposed policy changes is to increase the ability of refugees from certain East African countries – including South Sudan, Democratic Republic of Congo, and Somalia – to work. These refugees will be given increased access to work permits, financial services like M-PESA, and support to start businesses.</i>
Free movement	<i>One of the proposed policy changes is to allow refugees from certain East African countries – including South Sudan, Democratic Republic of Congo, and Somalia – to move freely throughout Kenya. These refugees will be able to settle into new neighbourhoods and live among Kenyan communities.</i>
Integrated settlements	<i>One of the proposed policy changes is to convert existing refugee camps into integrated settlements, where refugees from certain East African countries – including South Sudan, Democratic Republic of Congo, and Somalia – will live alongside local residents. Both refugees and Kenyans in these areas will be able to access services provided by donors and NGOs, such as healthcare and education.</i>

Notes: Exact wording as shown to respondents. The control arm received no policy text and was not asked the policy-support outcome.

Our second experiment tests whether support for integration varies across refugee groups (H2). Respondents were assigned with equal probability to one of the three frames: questions about “refugees” in general, “refugees from Somalia,” or “refugees from South Sudan” (see Table 2).¹¹ We measure three outcomes. First, respondents rated their support for Kenya hosting the referenced group and then explained their answer in an open-ended response, described below. Second, they rated their support for that group moving into their constituency if refugees were allowed to move throughout Kenya, which we use as a proxy for support for local integration. Both outcomes use five-point scales. Third, respondents

¹¹The two experiments are independently randomized and fully crossed, producing a 4×3 design with 261–292 respondents per cell. Each respondent is therefore assigned to both a policy arm and a nationality arm, but we analyze the two experiments separately.

assessed whether the referenced group had improved or worsened Kenya’s economy, security, and culture, each on a three-point scale.

Table 2: Nationality experiment: item wording

Outcome	Question wording
Support for hosting	<i>We now want to ask you more broadly about [GROUP]. To what extent do you support or oppose Kenya hosting [GROUP]?</i>
Explanation	<i>Why do you [SUPPORT/OPPOSE] Kenya hosting [GROUP]?</i>
Local settlement	<i>Imagine that the Kenyan government was going to enable refugees to move to different areas throughout the country. Would you support or oppose [GROUP] moving into [CONSTITUENCY]?</i>
Perceived effects	<i>Overall, do you think that the impact of [GROUP] on the following things has improved, stayed the same, worsened, or haven’t you heard enough to say?</i>
Economy	<i>Kenya’s economy, including jobs, businesses, taxes, prices, and services</i>
Security	<i>Kenya’s security, including crime, violence, and terrorism</i>
Culture	<i>Kenya’s culture, including community cohesion and identity</i>

Notes: Small capitals denote piped inserts. [GROUP] takes the value *refugees*, *refugees from Somalia*, or *refugees from South Sudan*. The same randomized insert is used across all items. [SUPPORT/OPPOSE] is piped from the hosting response, and [CONSTITUENCY] from the respondent’s reported constituency. Hosting and local-settlement support were measured on five-point scales and standardized for analysis. The explanation was open-ended and hand-coded, while perceived effects were measured on three-point scales.

For each experiment main analysis, let Y_i denote respondent i ’s support outcome, standardized to mean 0 and standard deviation 1 in the estimation sample. We estimate weighted least squares models of the form

$$Y_i = \alpha + \sum_j \beta_j T_{ij} + \varepsilon_i, \quad (1)$$

where T_{ij} indicates assignment to treatment arm j , with the baseline arm omitted. Models are weighted by post-stratification weights and estimated with HC1 robust standard errors. Each coefficient β_j estimates the average effect of arm j relative to the baseline. Integrated settlements is the baseline in the policy experiment, and the generic “refugees” frame in the nationality experiment.¹² The main analysis uses the nationally representative sample, and the covariate analysis uses the full sample with covariate adjustment.

¹²We report the work-rights-versus-free-movement comparison as a linear combination $\beta_{\text{work}} - \beta_{\text{move}}$, tested by a Wald test on the fitted model rather than by re-estimating with a different baseline.

5.2 Correlates of Support

We include a series of measures to understand how citizen characteristics affect attitudes toward refugee integration. To test H3, we measure economic vulnerability using *education*, *income*, and *unemployment*. We also distinguish forms of employment that may be especially exposed to refugee labor market participation. *Formal employment* identifies full- or part-time employees, *Informal employment* identifies self-employed or casually employed respondents,¹³ and *Agricultural occupation* identifies respondents working in farming or livestock.¹⁴ *Urban* indicates residence in a ward with a population density of at least 1,000 persons per km², based on the 2019 Kenya Census (Kenya National Bureau of Statistics, 2019). To test H4, *Socio. econ. concern* is a standardized measure of whether respondents believe Kenya’s economy has worsened over the previous twelve months.

To test H5, *Ethnic kin* identifies respondents who are of Somali ethnicity. For H6, *Close contact* identifies respondents who report knowing a refugee who is “close to [them], like a family member, partner, friend, or neighbor.” We also include a measure of geographical proximity, *Camp county*, which indicates residence in Turkana or Garissa. All models control for *Age* and *Gender*.

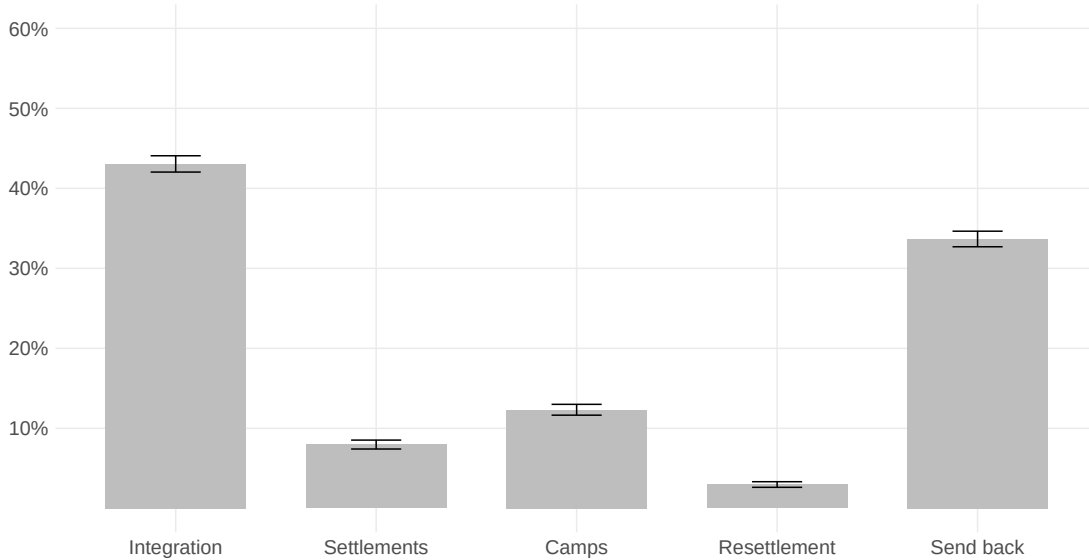
We analyze three outcomes. First, all respondents choose among five refugee-policy options: integration, settlements, camps, resettlement, or return. We code *Preference for integration* as 1 when a respondent selects integration, defined as granting refugees full legal rights in Kenya. Second, we examine support for each specific integration policy within the three treated arms of the policy experiment. Third, to assess whether the characteristics associated with support for integration differ from those associated with support for hosting, we analyze support for Kenya hosting refugees within the generic arm of the nationality experiment (see Section 6.4).

For the binary preference-for-integration outcome, we estimate a weighted logistic regression on the full sample and report average marginal effects in percentage points. For the experimental outcomes, we estimate weighted least squares models separately within each treatment arm, using standardized support as the outcome. All models use post-stratification weights, HC1 robust standard errors, and the same set of citizen characteristics. Because citizen characteristics are not randomized, these within-arm analyses are descriptive rather than causal. We also explore heterogeneous treatment effects by interacting each experimental arm with these characteristics. We treat this as a secondary analysis, discussing only the relevant findings in the text and reporting full results in the Appendix.

¹³Informality is commonly proxied by self-employment in LMICs (Elgin and Öztunalı, 2021; Fox and Sohnesen, 2012).

¹⁴We measured this using keywords given when participants are asked about their occupation, including “farm,” “horticulturist,” “herdsman,” “livestock,” and “pastoralist.”

Figure 2: Preferred Refugee Policies



Note: Weighted percent choosing each policy option (nationally representative sample); 95% CIs. $N = 2,472$.

5.3 Open-Ended Responses

We asked two open-ended questions to understand the mechanisms underlying attitudes toward integration. After the policy experiment, respondents in the treatment arms described the expected effects of the policy they had been shown. After the nationality experiment, respondents explained why they supported or opposed Kenya hosting the referenced refugee group. We developed a codebook from our theoretical framework and from a random 10 percent training sample, and then coded responses for references to specific categories. The full codebook and illustrative quotations appear in the Appendix.

6 Results

We begin by describing Kenyans' overall attitudes toward refugee integration before turning to the experimental results. As shown in Figure 2, integration is the most popular policy for refugees among Kenyan citizens. When asked to choose among five refugee policies, respondents most often selected integration (43.1%), while Kenya's status quo policy of encampment was less preferred (12.3%). However, a sizable minority (33.7%) favored returning refugees to their countries of origin. Majorities also backed each of the three integration measures tested in the experiment: 73.2% supported integrated settlements, 69.3% supported economic inclusion, and 59.9% supported free movement (Figure 3). Together, these results suggest a favorable public climate for refugee integration, alongside a sizable minority that prefers repatriation.

6.1 Survey Experiments

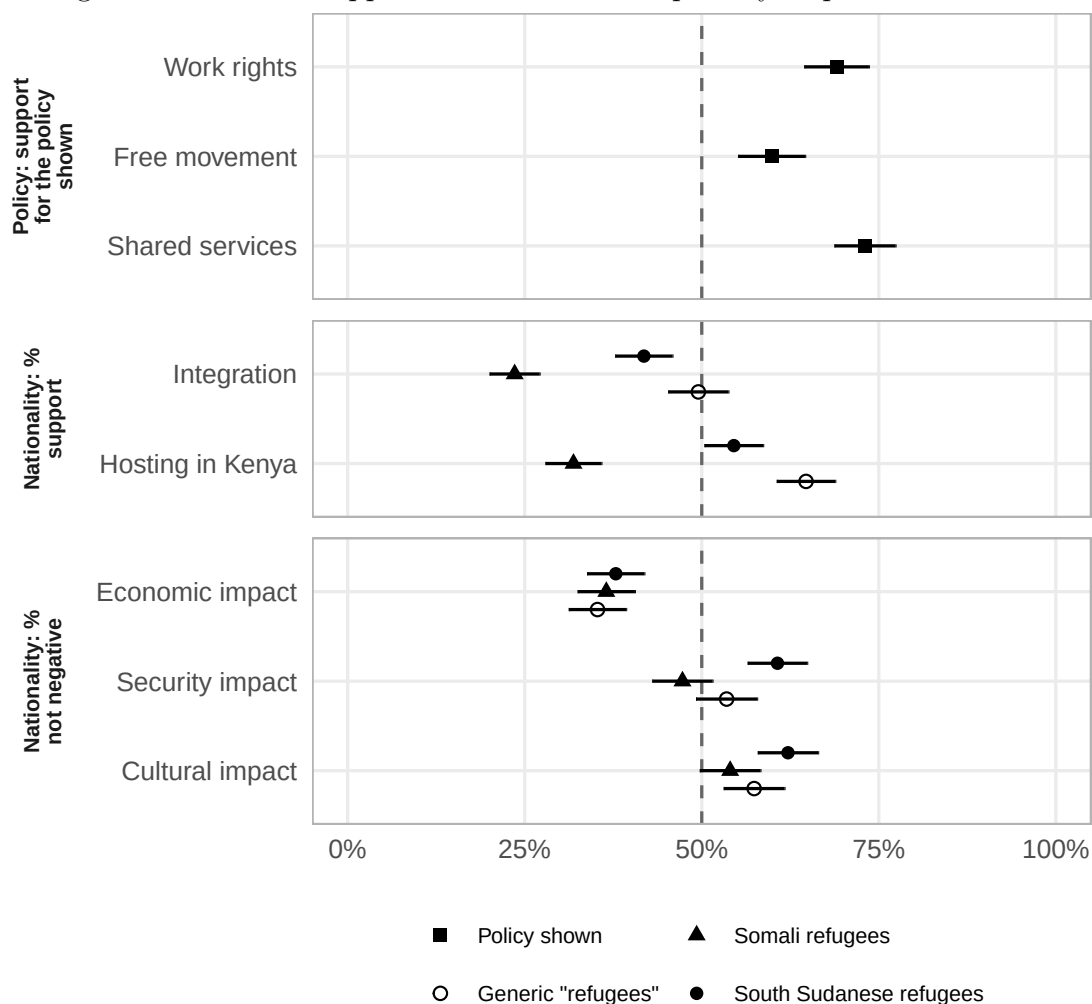
Table 3: Average Treatment Effects

Panel A. Policy experiment: support for the policy shown (SD)			
Work rights (vs. integrated settlements)	-0.038 (0.071)		
Free movement (vs. integrated settlements)	-0.291*** (0.074)		
Work rights (vs. free movement) [†]	0.252*** (0.073)		
Joint <i>p</i> (three arms)	0.000		
Observations	1,865		
R ²	0.016		
Panel B. Policy experiment: attitudes toward integration and hosting			
	Full rights (pp)	Hosting in Kenya (SD)	
Work rights (vs. control)	4.732 (3.475)	0.100 (0.128)	
Free movement (vs. control)	-2.847 (3.335)	0.048 (0.131)	
Integrated settlements (vs. control)	0.503 (3.380)	0.167 (0.129)	
<i>Any policy</i> (vs. control)	0.677 (2.760)	0.105 (0.109)	
Joint <i>p</i> (three arms)	0.182	0.590	
Observations	2,472	809	
R ²	0.003	0.004	
Panel C. Nationality experiment (SD)			
	Integration	Hosting in Kenya	
Somali refugees (vs. generic)	-0.534*** (0.059)	-0.708*** (0.062)	
South Sudanese refugees (vs. generic)	-0.151* (0.061)	-0.191** (0.061)	
Observations	2,485	2,468	
R ²	0.052	0.086	
	Economic impact	Security impact	Cultural impact
Somali refugees (vs. generic)	0.043 (0.062)	-0.103 ⁺ (0.063)	-0.075 (0.064)
South Sudanese refugees (vs. generic)	0.058 (0.061)	0.142* (0.063)	0.058 (0.063)
Observations	2,402	2,362	2,338
R ²	0.001	0.010	0.003

Notes: Standard errors in parentheses. Joint p tests that all arm coefficients are zero. *Hosting in Kenya* is estimated in the generic *refugees* arm only. [†]Linear combination of the two coefficients above it, with the covariance carried through. *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$, + $p < 0.10$.

Integration Policy Type. We find partial support for H1. Freedom of movement receives significantly less support than the other two policy dimensions, but contrary to our expectation, integrated settlements and economic inclusion are similarly popular (Table 3). Relative to freedom of movement, support is 0.252 SD higher in the economic inclusion arm (SE = 0.073, $p < 0.001$) and 0.291 SD higher in the integrated settlements arm (SE = 0.074, $p < 0.001$). Support does not differ significantly between economic inclusion and integrated settlements (−0.038 SD, SE = 0.071). Panel B shows no evidence that receiving information about integration policy changes broader attitudes toward integration or toward Kenya hosting refugees.

Figure 3: Levels of Support and Perceived Impact by Experimental Arm



Note: Weighted proportions on the nationally representative sample with 95% HC1 intervals; dashed line marks 50 percent. Support means a rating of 4 or 5 (somewhat or strongly support) on the five-point scale. The top panel gives the share supporting the policy the respondent was shown, for each of the three policy dimensions; the middle panel the share supporting integration and hosting, by the wording used. The perceived-impact items are three-point (negative / neutral / positive), so the bottom panel plots the share *not* reporting a negative impact. That is not a support measure and is not directly comparable to the panels above it.

Refugee Group. We find strong support for H2. Relative to the generic “refugees” wording, naming Somali refugees reduces support for local integration by 0.534 SD (SE = 0.059, $p < 0.001$), while naming South Sudanese refugees produces a smaller decline of 0.151 SD (SE = 0.061, $p < 0.05$) (Panel C of Table 3). The difference between the two named groups is 0.383 SD (SE = 0.056). Descriptively, 49.5% of respondents support refugees in general moving into their locality, compared with 41.8% for South Sudanese and 23.6% for Somali refugees (Figure 3). The same pattern appears for hosting, at higher overall levels: naming Somali refugees reduces support by 0.708 SD (SE = 0.062, $p < 0.001$) and naming South Sudanese by 0.191 SD (SE = 0.061, $p < 0.01$). Notably, naming any specific nationality reduces support relative to the abstract category.

The perceived-effects battery suggests that these differences are driven mainly by security and, to a lesser extent, culture rather than economics. Relative to refugees in general, naming Somali refugees worsens perceived security effects by 0.103 SD (SE = 0.063, $p < 0.10$). The gap between Somali and South Sudanese refugees is 0.244 SD for security (SE = 0.062, $p < 0.001$) and 0.133 SD for culture (SE = 0.063, $p < 0.05$). Descriptively, 52.7% say Somali refugees have worsened Kenya’s security, compared with 46.5% for refugees in general and 39.3% for South Sudanese refugees. Economic assessments are most negative of the three domains – 62–65% say refugees have worsened Kenya’s economy – but they vary little across groups (Figure 3). Kenyans are thus broadly pessimistic about refugees’ economic impact, but that pessimism is not group-specific and does not seem to account for the differences in support for integrating different refugee groups.

6.2 Correlates of Support

Table 4: Correlates of Support for Refugee Integration and Hosting

	(1) Preference for integration (pp)	(2) Support for work rights (SD)	(3) Support for free movement (SD)	(4) Support for integrated settlements (SD)	(5) Support for hosting in Kenya (SD)
Economic concerns					
Education (1 category)	3.72** (1.35)	-0.04 (0.05)	0.10* (0.05)	0.02 (0.06)	0.12** (0.04)
Income (1 SD)	1.85 (1.23)	0.06 (0.05)	-0.10* (0.05)	-0.00 (0.05)	0.07+ (0.04)
Unemployment	-0.79 (3.32)	-0.05 (0.12)	0.01 (0.13)	-0.05 (0.13)	-0.13 (0.11)
Formal employment	1.65 (3.74)	-0.01 (0.15)	-0.08 (0.16)	0.09 (0.14)	-0.01 (0.13)
Informal employment	0.28 (3.48)	0.04 (0.12)	0.19 (0.14)	-0.20 (0.13)	0.02 (0.12)
Urban	2.90 (2.44)	-0.05 (0.09)	-0.15 (0.10)	-0.00 (0.09)	-0.01 (0.07)
Agricultural occupation	0.12 (3.28)	-0.01 (0.13)	0.23+ (0.13)	0.01 (0.15)	0.02 (0.11)
Socio. econ. concern (1 SD)	-2.70* (1.09)	-0.02 (0.04)	-0.14*** (0.04)	-0.09* (0.04)	-0.07* (0.03)
Ethnic kinship and contact					
Kenyan Somali	21.08*** (3.72)	0.38** (0.12)	0.49** (0.16)	0.29* (0.13)	0.51*** (0.10)
Close contact	6.96** (2.50)	0.22** (0.08)	0.18+ (0.09)	0.14+ (0.09)	0.25*** (0.07)
Camp county	-3.59 (2.62)	0.05 (0.09)	0.25* (0.11)	0.14 (0.11)	0.11 (0.08)
Controls					
Age (1 SD)	-5.71*** (1.18)	-0.12** (0.05)	-0.14** (0.05)	-0.08 (0.05)	-0.05 (0.04)
Gender (Female = 1)	6.20** (2.23)	0.11 (0.09)	0.05 (0.09)	0.10 (0.09)	0.12 (0.07)
Outcome mean	46.0%	3.86	3.52	3.95	3.73
Outcome SD (1–5 scale)	—	1.51	1.65	1.52	1.54
Observations	2,922	729	750	731	974
R ²	0.061	0.058	0.130	0.071	0.132

Notes: Standard errors in parentheses. Column 1 reports average marginal effects. Outcomes in columns 2–5 are standardised on the pooled sample, so converting to the underlying 1–5 scale requires the pooled standard deviation actually used as the divisor, which is the unweighted full-sample value (1.55 for policy support, 1.65 for hosting) and not the arm-specific values shown. The appendix summary table reports weighted standard deviations for the same items, which are slightly larger for that reason. Estimation samples are restricted only by arm and by complete cases on the covariates; respondents already aware of the Shirika Plan and those failing the manipulation check are retained. *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$, + $p < 0.10$.

Table 4 reports five models examining variation in who supports integration and hosting. Column 1 estimates preference for integration in the full sample, Columns 2–4 estimate standardized support within each policy-treatment arm, and column 5 estimates support for hosting in general.¹⁵

Economic Concerns. We find little support for H3. Economic vulnerability is not consistently related to support for integration. Unemployment, agricultural occupation, and

¹⁵Column 1 is measured in percentage points, whereas columns 2–5 are measured in standard deviations. Sample sizes also differ substantially (2,922 in column 1 and 729–974 in columns 2–5), so differences in statistical significance partly reflect statistical power. All models include the Turkana and Garissa oversamples.

employment formality show no reliable association with any outcome, and none of our measures predicts support for economic inclusion, the dimension mostly directly concerned with labor market access and where economic-threat accounts would most clearly expect opposition. Education and income are the exceptions, and they point in opposite directions. Each additional education category is associated with a 3.72 percentage-point increase in preference for integration ($SE = 1.35$, $p < 0.01$), as well as greater support for free movement (0.10 SD, $SE = 0.05$, $p < 0.05$) and for hosting refugees (0.12 SD, $SE = 0.04$, $p < 0.01$).¹⁶ Higher income, by contrast, is associated with lower support for free movement (-0.10 SD, $SE = 0.05$, $p < 0.05$), though it does not predict other outcomes. Although respondents' economic position does not predict overall support, secondary heterogeneity analysis suggests that formally employed respondents are relatively less favorable toward free movement than integrated settlements, while informally employed respondents are more favorable toward free movement and economic inclusion (Appendix).

Evidence for H4 is mixed. Sociotropic economic concern is associated with a 2.70 percentage-point decline in preference for integration ($SE = 1.09$, $p < 0.05$), as well as lower support for free movement (-0.14 SD, $SE = 0.04$, $p < 0.001$), integrated settlements (-0.09 SD, $SE = 0.04$, $p < 0.05$), and hosting refugees in Kenya (-0.07 SD, $SE = 0.03$, $p < 0.05$). However, these associations are substantively small and do not survive many robustness checks (see Appendix). Overall, these findings suggest that citizens pessimistic about the economy are somewhat more negative toward refugees. But this pessimism shapes opposition to integration only weakly, and not at all for economic inclusion, the policy that would likely most directly affect Kenya's economy.

Ethnic Kinship and Close Contact. We find strong support for H5. Ethnic kinship is the strongest predictor of support for integration. Kenyan Somali respondents are 21.1 percentage points more likely to prefer integration ($SE = 3.7$, $p < 0.001$), express greater support for all three integration policies (0.38 SD for economic inclusion, $SE = 0.12$; 0.49 SD for free movement, $SE = 0.16$; and 0.29 SD for integrated settlements, $SE = 0.13$), and are also more supportive of Kenya hosting refugees in general (0.51 SD, $SE = 0.10$, $p < 0.001$; Table 4).

The heterogeneity analysis shows that ethnic kin are not only more supportive of integration in general, but distinctively supportive of integrating their own kin. Among Kenyan Somali respondents, the Somali penalty is 0.605 SD smaller for local integration ($SE = 0.149$, $p < 0.001$) and 0.748 SD smaller for hosting ($SE = 0.106$, $p < 0.001$), offsetting most of the average penalty reported in Table 3. The same respondents show no comparable shift in the South Sudanese arm (-0.045 SD, $SE = 0.156$; and 0.003 SD, $SE = 0.131$), indicating an effect specific to their own kin.

We also find support for H6. Respondents with close contact with refugees are 7.0 percentage

¹⁶This is consistent with evidence from HICs that higher education is associated with pro-immigration attitudes because it reflects values and information rather than economic concerns (Hainmueller and Hiscox, 2010).

points more likely to prefer integration ($SE = 2.5$, $p < 0.01$) and 0.25 SD more supportive of Kenya hosting refugees ($SE = 0.07$, $p < 0.001$). Coefficients are positive for all three policy dimensions – economic inclusion (0.22 SD, $SE = 0.08$, $p < 0.01$), free movement (0.18 SD, $SE = 0.09$), and integrated settlements (0.14 SD, $SE = 0.09$) – though the latter two estimates are less precise. Support is also descriptively higher near refugee camps. Among respondents in camp-hosting counties, 50.5% prefer integration, compared with 43.4% elsewhere.

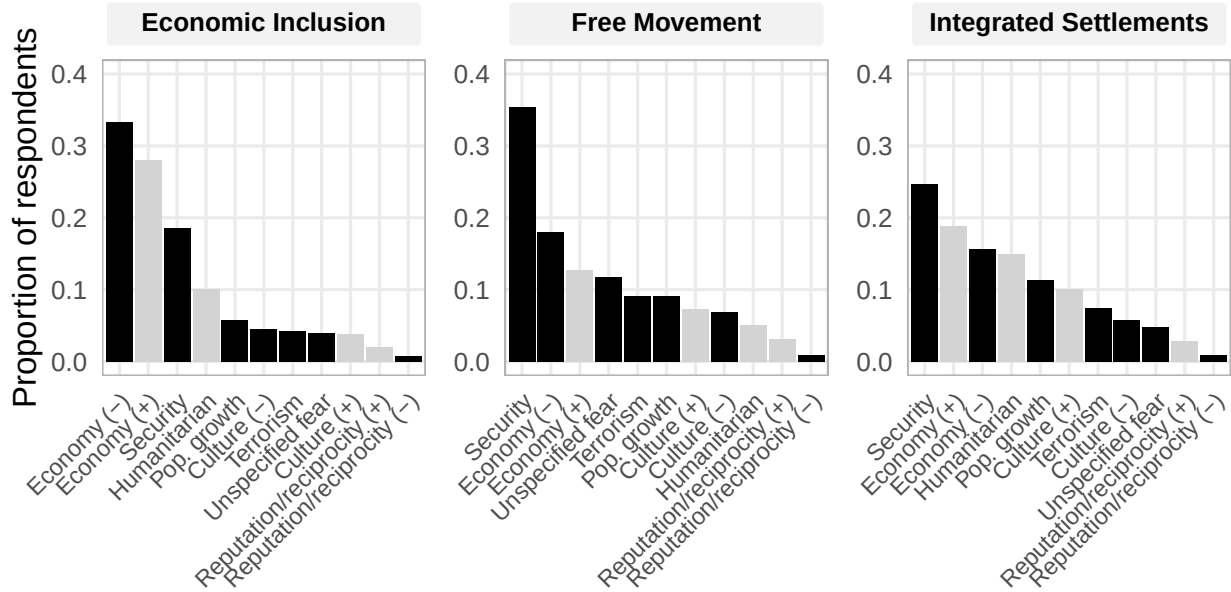
Support is also higher for economic inclusion (78.6% versus 69.1%), free movement (77.7% versus 58.2%), and integrated settlements (84.2% versus 72.3%). However, once ethnic kinship and close contact are controlled for, residence in a camp county no longer predicts preference for integration, economic inclusion, or integrated settlements. It continues to predict greater support for free movement, however (0.25 SD, $SE = 0.11$, $p < 0.05$). This suggests that the higher support observed in refugee hosting areas is largely driven by residents’ ethnic and interpersonal ties to refugees rather than proximity alone.

6.3 Open-ended Questions

Integration Policy Type. Open-ended responses point to different concerns across the three dimensions of integration. Opposition to free movement is driven mainly by security fears: 36% of respondents in that arm mentioned insecurity, and 9% referred specifically to terrorism (Figure 4). As one respondent explained, “allowing them to move freely can bring about criminal acts.” Security was also the most common theme in the integrated settlements arm, raised by 25% of respondents, who worried that shared services could generate conflict or attract more refugees to Kenya and lead to overpopulation.

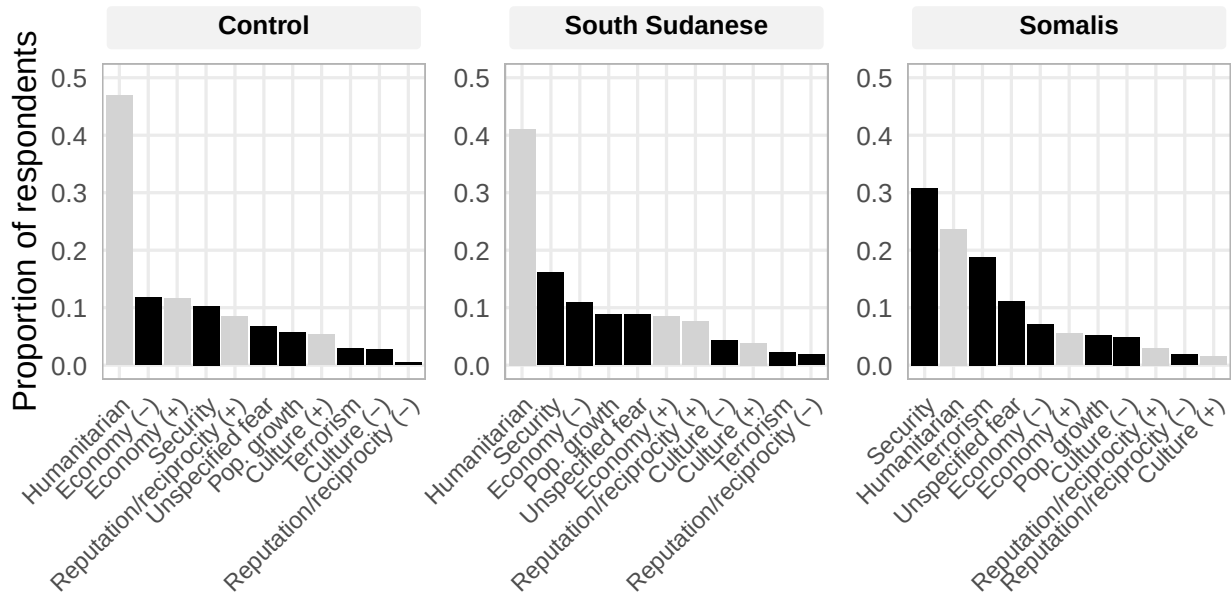
Responses to economic inclusion focused instead on economic consequences, with positive and negative assessments in roughly equal measure. Some respondents raised concerns about job competition, inflation, or favoritism, arguing that “the government helps refugees and forgets Kenyans.” Others anticipated greater business activity, job creation, demand for local goods and services, and tax revenue: “Economic growth because if they are able to work they will be able to pay taxes.” Integrated settlements was the only arm in which positive economic mentions exceeded negative ones (18.8% versus 15.7%). Respondents frequently noted that international organizations would finance the services provided: “It will have a positive effect, because it won’t affect the economy, reason being they will be under NGOs.” This is consistent with the argument that shared services in LMICs can directly benefit nearby citizens rather than simply impose costs on them.

Figure 4: Policy Experiment: Open-Ended Explanations



Note: Bars show the share of open-ended respondents mentioning each theme, in the work-rights, free-movement, and integrated-settlements arms (nationally representative sample). $N = 1,262$ respondents; $N = 1,483$ coded mentions. Dark = negative concern; light = positive benefit. See Appendix for coding.

Figure 5: Nationality Experiment: Open-Ended Explanations



Note: Bars show the share of open-ended respondents mentioning each theme, by the wording used (nationally representative sample). $N = 2,137$ respondents; $N = 2,425$ coded mentions. Dark = negative concern; light = positive benefit. See Appendix for coding.

Refugee Group. Open-ended responses indicate that security is the dominant source of opposition to hosting and integrating Somali refugees. Among respondents discussing Somalis, 31% referenced insecurity and 19% terrorism specifically, against 10% and 3% for refugees in general (Figure 5). For example, one respondent said, “Tanzanians are here and we don’t have a problem, even Ugandans are here in Mombasa and Nairobi but they don’t have a problem...but Somalis, they have Al Shabaab.” Security concerns were also somewhat more common for South Sudanese refugees than for refugees in general (16% versus 10%), though these centered on resource competition and crime rather than terrorism.

Economic perceptions, however, point in the opposite direction. Respondents expressed relatively few negative economic views about Somalis, who were often described as commercially successful or contributing positively to local markets. For example, one respondent said, “the Somali people have money and thus make the Kenyan economy to rise.” South Sudanese refugees, by contrast, were more often portrayed as economically unproductive: “They don’t help Kenya in any way in generating revenue i.e., paying taxes.” The group viewed more favorably in economic terms is therefore the one citizens are less willing to integrate, suggesting that perceived economic contribution does not offset security concerns.

Humanitarian motives also featured prominently in support for hosting. Nearly half of respondents in the control group invoked shared humanity or the need to help those fleeing danger. For example, “They are human beings like us.” Many also expressed empathy rooted in the possibility that displacement could one day affect Kenyans themselves: “They’re humans and they’re supposed to be helped. The same way it might become worse in Kenya and we run to their country. It’s brotherhood.”

6.4 Comparing Integration and Hosting

This paper has posited that attitudes toward integration may differ from attitudes toward hosting. Allowing refugees to work, move freely, and share services may raise concerns that are less salient when refugees remain in camps or outside the formal labor market. In this section, we examine what our findings show about that distinction.

Attitudes toward hosting and integration are closely related. Respondents who are more supportive of Kenya hosting refugees are also more likely to support integration. Average support for hosting rises across preferred policy options, from 2.52 on the five-point scale among respondents who prefer return, to 3.85 among those who prefer camps, 4.18 among those who prefer settlements, and 4.47 among those who prefer integration.

The two are not interchangeable, however, and there is some divergence between support for hosting and support for integration. While 64.7% of respondents support Kenya hosting refugees, only 43.1% select integration from the policy menu, and 30.8% support hosting while preferring another policy. This gap appears to be driven largely by opposition to refugees leaving the camps. In the policy experiment, support for economic inclusion (69.3%) and integrated settlements (73.2%) exceeds support for hosting refugees generally (64.7%), whereas support for freedom of movement is lower (59.9%). Most citizens are therefore willing to extend substantial rights to refugees, including beyond camp settings, but a sizeable

minority oppose freedom of movement and prefer refugees to receive greater rights while remaining in established camp-hosting areas, largely out of fears of insecurity.

We also examine whether different types of citizens support hosting and integration. We expected economically vulnerable citizens to be more accepting of hosting than integration, since work and movement rights could expose them more directly to labor market competition. We find little evidence of this. Ethnic kinship and close contact with refugees predict greater support for both outcomes, while individual economic vulnerability predicts neither. Comparing the 12.3% of the population who prefer camps with the 43.1% who prefer integration, those who choose camps are older, more likely to be male, more concerned about the national economy, considerably less likely to be Kenyan Somali, and more likely to live in a camp-hosting county (see Appendix). Residents of Turkana and Garissa are less restrictive overall, but prefer that refugees remain in the camp rather than integrate. This could reflect the aid-based benefits these local residents get from the camps.

6.5 Robustness Checks

We report an extensive set of robustness checks in the Appendix. We show that the weighted sample is representative of the Kenyan population on age, gender, province, and education, and that the treatment arms of both experiments are balanced on observables.

We probe the experimental results in three ways. First, we vary the estimator: alongside the weighted least squares estimates reported in the main text, the Appendix presents unadjusted differences in means, Mann–Whitney tests, unweighted estimates, and average treatment effects estimated using causal forests. Second, we vary the sample. We re-estimate the policy experiment excluding the 12.2 percent of nationally representative respondents who failed the post-treatment comprehension check and the 1.3 percent who were already aware of the policy,¹⁷ and we re-estimate both experiments on the full sample including the Turkana and Garissa oversamples. Third, we address possible contamination from the survey flow, in which the policy experiment precedes the nationality experiment: we re-estimate the nationality experiment using only respondents assigned to the control condition of the policy experiment, and we directly test whether receiving information about any policy dimension shifted responses to downstream questions, finding no evidence that it did (Panel B of Table 3). Across these checks, the magnitude, direction, and statistical significance of the experimental results are substantively unchanged. We also report exploratory heterogeneous treatment effects, interacting each experimental arm with the full set of citizen characteristics.

For the analysis of citizen characteristics, we first vary the specification, re-estimating the binary preference-for-integration model as a linear probability model, without covariate adjustment, and without weights. Second, we vary the variable measurement: we recode

¹⁷We retain these respondents in the main analysis because failure rates differ across the treated arms and are related to respondent characteristics, in particular education, so excluding them would change the composition of the groups being compared rather than simply removing noise. The Appendix reports the excluded estimates and failure rates by arm.

exposure to refugees using self-reported local refugee presence rather than camp geography; use a more precise geographic indicator of being in a camp constituency rather than county; replace the binary urban indicator with continuous population density; use an alternative measure of sociotropic economic concern; and examine Nilotic ethnolinguistic affiliation as an alternative measure of ethnic kinship. Third, we examine two different outcomes: a feeling thermometer toward refugees in Kenya and a measure of concern about refugee hosting as an issue facing the country. Finally, we probe functional form by relaxing linearity assumptions for continuous and binned covariates. The kinship and contact results are robust. The sociotropic-concern associations are the least stable, reflecting their small magnitude.

We expect concerns about social desirability bias to be limited in this setting. Fewer than 2% of respondents could accurately describe Kenya’s new refugee law at the time of the survey, and refugee policy was not a salient issue in national politics or media (Castillejo, 2021; Dafoe, Zhang and Caughey, 2021). Moreover, in both the closed- and open-ended questions, many respondents expressed negative views about refugees, suggesting that respondents did not feel constrained to give favorable answers.

7 Conclusion

Most of the world’s refugees live in LMICs, where the central policy question is not whether to admit refugees but whether to integrate those already present. This paper provides one of the first nationally representative assessments of attitudes toward refugee integration in a major host country in the Global South, fielded between the passage of a landmark integration law and its implementation. There are three key takeaways.

First, public support for integration is relatively high, although hosting and integration are not interchangeable. Integration is the most frequently preferred policy option and is roughly four times more popular than encampment, Kenya’s longstanding approach to refugee hosting. Majorities also support each dimension of the new integration policy. Yet support for hosting is broader than support for full integration: 64.7% support Kenya hosting refugees, while 43.1% select integration, and a meaningful minority supports hosting without granting refugees full rights.

Second, the principal dividing line on integration is whether refugees should be allowed to leave the camps, with opposition driven more by security concerns than by economic competition. When examining different types of integration policies, support for both economic inclusion and integrated settlements is high, while support for freedom of movement is significantly lower. Respondents explain this gap primarily in terms of crime, terrorism, and the risk that conflicts from refugees’ countries of origin could spread into Kenya. The same pattern appears when examining support for different refugee groups: Somali refugees, who are most strongly associated with insecurity, receive substantially less support than refugees in general or South Sudanese refugees. Economic considerations matter less than expected. Support remains high for economic inclusion, personal economic vulnerability does not consistently predict attitudes, and respondents identify economic benefits as well as costs.

Third, many of the same factors underlie support for hosting and integration. Ethnic kinship and close personal contact are the strongest predictors of favorable attitudes toward both, while personal economic circumstances predict neither and sociotropic economic concerns are only weakly associated with support. Respondents' explanations also reveal a strong humanitarian basis for support, consistent with evidence that humanitarian considerations can outweigh material concerns (Bansak, Hainmueller and Hangartner, 2016; Alrababa'h et al., 2021).

These findings have implications for research on public attitudes toward displaced populations. Much of the existing literature focuses on admission decisions in HICs and emphasizes economic and cultural threat (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2014; Weber et al., 2025). Our results suggest that this framework applies only partly to countries where most refugees live. In such contexts, security concerns are the major factor associated with opposition, and nationwide economic concerns play a more limited role.

A limitation of this study is that it examines a single context, raising questions about generalizability. Nevertheless, the findings may inform research on integration beyond Kenya. UNHCR and the World Bank are promoting reforms across many refugee-hosting countries, and because we examine economic inclusion, freedom of movement, and shared services separately, our framework can be applied widely, including where governments adopt only one component. The mobility findings are most directly relevant to camp-based settings, where roughly one in five refugees worldwide, about eight million people, lives (Anti et al., 2025; UNHCR, 2026*b*). The limited role of personal economic vulnerability and the salience of perceived economic benefits may also extend to LMICs with large informal economies and limited welfare provision. Security concerns may be especially important in countries neighboring active conflicts, where integration can raise fears of cross-border instability. Comparative research should test how support varies across integration policies and these broader scope conditions.

Overall, the results suggest that refugee integration may be politically feasible in LMICs. As return and resettlement remain unavailable to most displaced people, local integration has become an increasingly important durable solution (Miliband, 2019). In Kenya, support is stronger than often assumed, particularly among citizens with social ties to refugees, who recognize economic benefits, or express humanitarian commitments. Opposition is concentrated not on integration itself, but on policies that allow refugees to leave camps and on groups associated with insecurity. Work rights and integrated settlements may therefore be more politically acceptable than freedom of movement. Moving beyond encampment will depend not only on demonstrating the benefits of integration, but also on addressing the security concerns that make mobility its most contested dimension.

Data Availability Statement

The data and replication materials supporting this study will be deposited in the Harvard Dataverse, together with the code required to reproduce all tables and figures in the manuscript.

References

- Abdelaaty, Lamis Elmy. 2021. *Discrimination and delegation: Explaining state responses to refugees*. Oxford University Press.
- Adida, Claire L, Adeline Lo and Melina R Platas. 2019. “Americans preferred Syrian refugees who are female, English-speaking, and Christian on the eve of Donald Trump’s election.” *PloS one* 14(10):e0222504.
- Adida, Claire L, David D Laitin and Marie-Anne Valfort. 2016. *Why Muslim integration fails in Christian-heritage societies*. Harvard University Press.
- Ahrens, Achim, Andreas Beerli, Dominik Hangartner, Selina Kurer and Michael Siegenthaler. 2023. The Labor Market Effects of Restricting Refugees’ Employment Opportunities. IZA Discussion Paper 15901 IZA Institute of Labor Economics Bonn: .
URL: <https://docs.iza.org/dp15901.pdf>
- Aksoy, Cevat Giray, Thomas Ginn and Franco Malpassi. 2024. Attitudes and Policies toward Refugees: Evidence from Low- and Middle-Income Countries. Technical report World Bank-UNHCR Joint Data Center on Forced Displacement.
URL: <https://www.jointdatacenter.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/Ginn-1.pdf>
- Aksu, Ege, Refik Erzan and Murat Güray Kırdar. 2022. “The impact of mass migration of Syrians on the Turkish labor market.” *Labour Economics* 76:102183.
- Alix-Garcia, Jennifer, Sarah Walker, Anne Bartlett, Harun Onder and Apurva Sanghi. 2018. “Do refugee camps help or hurt hosts? The case of Kakuma, Kenya.” *Journal of Development Economics* 130:66–83.
- Allen, William, Isabel Ruiz and Carlos Vargas Silva. 2022. *Policy preferences in response to large migration inflows*. World Bank.
- Allen, William L, Isabel Ruiz and Carlos Vargas-Silva. 2024. “Policy preferences in response to large forced migration inflows.” *World Development* 174:106462.
- Allen, William L, Matthew D Bird, Luisa Feline Freier, Isabel Ruiz and Carlos Vargas-Silva. 2024. Migration policy preferences and forms of trust in contexts of limited state capacity. Technical report Nottingham Interdisciplinary Centre for Economic and Political Research (NICEP).
- Allport, Gordon W. 1954. *The Nature of Prejudice*. Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley.
- Alrababa’h, Ala’, Andrea Dillon, Scott Williamson, Jens Hainmueller, Dominik Hangartner and Jeremy Weinstein. 2021. “Attitudes toward migrants in a highly impacted economy: Evidence from the Syrian refugee crisis in Jordan.” *Comparative Political Studies* 54(1):33–76.
- Amnesty International. 2014. “Kenya: Somalis Scapegoated in Counter-Terror Crackdown.”. Accessed November 14, 2024.
URL: <https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/press-release/2014/05/kenya-somalis-scapegoated-counter-terror-crackdown/>

- Anti, Sebastian, Colette Salemi, Jonathan Rigberg, Karishma Silva and Johannes Hoogeveen. 2025. “A New Expanded Dataset to Study Refugee Camps in Sub-Saharan Africa 1999–2024.” Working paper.
URL: https://colettesalemi.ca/files/Anti_etal_2025.pdf
- Bahar, Dany, Bo Cowgill and Jorge Guzman. 2022. “The Economic Effects of Immigration Pardons: Evidence from Venezuelan Entrepreneurs in Colombia.”. SSRN Working Paper.
URL: https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=4155358
- Bahar, Dany and Meagan Dooley. 2019. No Refugees and Migrants Left Behind. In *Leave No One Behind: Time for Specifics on the Sustainable Development Goals*, ed. Homi Kharas, John McArthur and Izumi Ohno. Washington, DC: Brookings Institution Press pp. 79–104.
URL: <https://www.brookings.edu/wp-content/uploads/2019/09/LNOBchapter5.pdf>
- Balkan, Binnur, Elif Tok, Huzeyfe Torun and Semih Tumen. 2018. Immigration, Housing Rents, and Residential Segregation: Evidence from Syrian Refugees in Turkey. IZA Discussion Paper 11611 IZA Institute of Labor Economics.
- Bansak, Kirk, Jens Hainmueller and Dominik Hangartner. 2016. “How economic, humanitarian, and religious concerns shape European attitudes toward asylum seekers.” *Science* 354(6309):217–222.
- Bansak, Kirk, Jens Hainmueller and Dominik Hangartner. 2023. “Europeans’ support for refugees of varying background is stable over time.” *Nature* 620(7975):849–854.
- Betts, Alexander, Maria Flinder Stierna, Naohiko Omata and Olivier Sterck. 2023. “Refugees Welcome? Inter-group Interaction and Host Community Attitude Formation.” *World Development* 161:106088.
- Betts, Alexander, Maria Flinder Stierna, Naohiko Omata and Olivier Sterck. 2024. “The Economic Lives of Refugees.” *World Development* 182:106693.
- Betts, Alexander, Naohiko Omata and Olivier Sterck. 2018. Refugee Economies in Kenya. Technical report Refugee Studies Centre. Accessed November 14, 2024.
URL: <https://www.rsc.ox.ac.uk/publications/refugee-economies-in-kenya>
- Betts, Alexander, Naohiko Omata and Olivier Sterck. 2020. “The Kalobeyei settlement: A self-reliance model for refugees?” *Journal of Refugee Studies* 33(1):189–223.
- Blair, Christopher W, Guy Grossman and Jeremy M Weinstein. 2022. “Forced displacement and asylum policy in the developing world.” *International Organization* 76(2):337–378.
- Böhmelt, Tobias, Vincenzo Bove and Enzo Nussio. 2020. “Can Terrorism Abroad Influence Migration Attitudes at Home?” *American Journal of Political Science* 64(3):437–451.
- Bousquet, Julie, Anna Gasten, Mark Marvin Kadigo, Jean-François Maystadt and Colette Salemi. 2025. “Does perceived labor market competition increase prejudice between refugees and their local hosts?”.

- Campbell, Elizabeth H. 2006. “Urban Refugees in Nairobi: Problems of Protection, Mechanisms of Survival, and Possibilities for Integration.” *Journal of Refugee Studies* 19(3):396–413.
URL: <https://academic.oup.com/jrs/article/19/3/396/1571241>
- Campo, Francesco, Sara Giunti, Mariapia Mendola and Giulia Tura. 2023. Political Backlash to Refugee Settlement: Cultural and Economic Drivers. Technical report IZA Discussion Papers.
- Capital FM News. 2024. “Govt Allays Fears Shirika Plan Will Give Kakuma, Dadaab Refugees Voting Rights.”. Accessed 2025-10-15.
URL: <https://www.capitalfm.co.ke/news/2024/11/govt-allays-fears-shirika-plan-will-give-kakuma-daadab-refugees-voting-rights/>
- Card, David, Christian Dustmann and Ian Preston. 2012. “Immigration, Wages, and Compositional Amenities.” *Journal of the European Economic Association* 10(1):78–119.
URL: <https://academic.oup.com/jeea/article/10/1/78/2182014>
- Carrier, Neil. 2016. *Little Mogadishu: Eastleigh, Nairobi’s Global Somali Hub*. London: Hurst Publishers.
- Castillejo, Clare. 2021. Kenya: Migration and Asylum Country Profile. Technical report Overseas Development Institute.
URL: https://odi.org/documents/6209/kenya_migration_country_profile_final.pdf
- Ceritoglu, Evren, H Burcu Gurcihan Yunculer, Huzeyfe Torun and Semih Tumen. 2017. “The impact of Syrian refugees on natives’ labor market outcomes in Turkey: evidence from a quasi-experimental design.” *IZA Journal of Labor Policy* 6:1–28.
- Clemens, Michael A., Cindy Huang and Jimmy Graham. 2018. The Economic and Fiscal Effects of Granting Refugees Formal Labor Market Access. CGD Working Paper 496 Center for Global Development Washington, DC: . RePEc:cgd:wpaper:496.
URL: <https://www.cgdev.org/sites/default/files/economic-and-fiscal-effects-granting-refugees-formal-labor-market-access.pdf>
- Cogley, Nathaniel Terence, John Andrew Doces and Beth Elise Whitaker. 2019. “Which Immigrants Should Be Naturalized? Which Should Be Deported? Evidence from a Survey Experiment in Côte d’Ivoire.” *Political Research Quarterly* 72(3):653–668.
- Crisp, Jeff. 2004. “Local Integration and Local Settlement of Refugees: A Conceptual and Historical Analysis.” UNHCR. Accessed: 2024-12-24.
URL: <https://www.unhcr.org/us/media/local-integration-and-local-settlement-refugees-conceptual-and-historical-analysis-jeff-crisp>
- Dafoe, Allan, Baobao Zhang and Devin Caughey. 2021. “Testing social desirability bias in survey experiments.” *American Journal of Political Science* 65(2):534–549.
URL: <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12572>
- Dagnelie, Olivier, Anna Maria Mayda and Jean-François Maystadt. 2023. Refugees, children’s health and malaria transmission in Africa. Cepr discussion paper no. 18284 Centre

for Economic Policy Research.

URL: <https://cepr.org/publications/dp18284>

De Haas, Hein, Katharina Natter and Simona Vezzoli. 2018. “Growing restrictiveness or changing selection? The nature and evolution of migration Policies.” *International Migration Review* 52(2):324–367.

de la Chaux, Marlen and Helen Haugh. 2020. “When Formal Institutions Impede Entrepreneurship: How and Why Refugees Establish New Ventures in the Dadaab Refugee Camps.” *Entrepreneurship & Regional Development* 32(9–10):827–851.

URL: <https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/08985626.2020.1789752>

Del Carpio, Ximena V and Mathis C Wagner. 2015. “The impact of Syrian refugees on the Turkish labor market.” *World Bank policy research working paper* (7402).

Elgin, Ceyhun and Serkan Öztunalı. 2021. “Understanding Informality.” SSRN Working Paper, ID 3914265.

URL: https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=3914265

Fisk, Kerstin. 2019. “Camp settlement and communal conflict in sub-Saharan Africa.” *Journal of Peace Research* 56(1):58–72.

Fox, Louise and Thomas Pave Sohnesen. 2012. Household Enterprises in Sub-Saharan Africa: Why They Matter for Growth, Jobs, and Livelihoods. Policy Research Working Paper 6184 World Bank Washington, DC: .

Gale, Lacey Andrews. 2006. “Sustaining relationships across borders: gendered livelihoods and mobility among Sierra Leonean refugees.” *Refugee Survey Quarterly* 25(2):69–80.

Getmansky, Anna, Tolga Sinmazdemir and Thomas Zeitzoff. 2018. “Refugees, xenophobia, and domestic conflict: Evidence from a survey experiment in Turkey.” *Journal of Peace Research* 55(4):491–507.

Getmansky, Anna, Tolga Sinmazdemir and Thomas Zeitzoff. 2018. Who Welcomes Refugees to the Public Purse? Evidence from a Survey in Turkey. In *POMEPS Studies 31: Social Policy in the Middle East and North Africa*. Project on Middle East Political Science.

Ghosn, Faten, Alex Braithwaite and Tiffany S Chu. 2019. “Violence, displacement, contact, and attitudes toward hosting refugees.” *Journal of Peace Research* 56(1):118–133.

Groeger, Andre, Gianmarco León-Ciliotta and Steven Stillman. 2024. “Immigration, labor markets and discrimination: Evidence from the Venezuelan Exodus in Perú.” *World Development* 174:106437.

Gülek, Ahmet. 2024. “Formal Effects of Informal Labor: Evidence from Syrian Refugees in Turkey.” SSRN Working Paper. Last revised July 1, 2025.

URL: <https://ssrn.com/abstract=4264865>

Hainmueller, Jens. 2012. “Entropy balancing for causal effects: A multivariate reweighting method to produce balanced samples in observational studies.” *Political Analysis* 20(1):25–46.

- Hainmueller, Jens and Daniel J Hopkins. 2014. "Public attitudes toward immigration." *Annual Review of Political Science* 17(1):225–249.
- Hainmueller, Jens and Daniel J Hopkins. 2015. "The hidden American immigration consensus: A conjoint analysis of attitudes toward immigrants." *American journal of political science* 59(3):529–548.
- Hainmueller, Jens and Michael J Hiscox. 2010. "Attitudes toward highly skilled and low-skilled immigration: Evidence from a survey experiment." *American political science review* 104(1):61–84.
- Halakhe, Abdullahi Boru and Samson Omondi. 2024. "Lessons and Recommendations for Implementing Kenya's New Refugee Law." Accessed November 15, 2024.
URL: <https://www.refugeesinternational.org/reports-briefs/lessons-and-recommendations-for-implementing-kenyas-new-refugee-law/>
- Hangartner, Dominik, Elias Dinas, Moritz Marbach, Konstantinos Matakos and Dimitrios Xefteris. 2019. "Does exposure to the refugee crisis make natives more hostile?" *American political science review* 113(2):442–455.
- Hovil, Lucy. 2014. Local Integration. In *The Oxford Handbook of Refugee and Forced Migration Studies*, ed. Elena Fiddian-Qasmiyeh, Gil Loescher, Katy Long and Nando Sigona. Oxford University Press pp. 488–498.
URL: <https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/28193/chapter/213138213>
- Ibáñez, Ana María, Andrés Moya, María Adelaida Ortega, Sandra V. Roza and María José Urbina. 2025. "Life Out of the Shadows: The Impacts of Regularization Programs on the Lives of Forced Migrants." *Journal of the European Economic Association* 23(3):941–982.
URL: <https://academic.oup.com/jeea/article/23/3/941/7754169>
- International Development Association. 2020. Window for Host Communities and Refugees. Technical report World Bank Washington, DC: .
URL: <https://ida.worldbank.org/en/replenishments/ida19-replenishment/windows-host-communities-refugees>
- Jaji, Rose. 2022. "Historical Complexities and Transformations of Refugee Policies in Kenya and Tanzania." *Africa Today* 69(1-2):88–109. Accessed November 14, 2024.
URL: <https://muse.jhu.edu/article/864870>
- Jansen, Bram J. and Milou de Bruijne. 2020. "Humanitarian Spill-over: The Expansion of Hybrid Humanitarian Governance from Camps to Refugee Hosting Societies in East Africa." *Journal of Eastern African Studies* 14(4):669–688.
URL: <https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/17531055.2020.1832292>
- Jeannet, Anne-Marie, Tobias Heidland and Martin Ruhs. 2021. "What asylum and refugee policies do Europeans want? Evidence from a cross-national conjoint experiment." *European Union Politics* 22(3):353–376.
- Kaderabek, A. 2022. "Assessing Measurement Error in Hypothetical Questions." *Survey Practice* 15(2):1–12.

- URL:** <https://www.surveypractice.org/article/38280-assessing-measurement-error-in-hypothetical-questions>
- Kenya National Bureau of Statistics. 2019. 2019 Kenya Population and Housing Census: Volume II – Distribution of Population by Administrative Units. Technical report Kenya National Bureau of Statistics.
- URL:** <https://www.knbs.or.ke/?wpdmpro=2019-kenya-population-and-housing-census-volume-ii-distribution-of-population-by-administrative-units>
- Lebow, Jeremy. 2022. “The labor market effects of Venezuelan migration to Colombia: reconciling conflicting results.” *IZA Journal of Development and Migration* 13(1).
- Legewie, Joscha. 2013. “Terrorist Events and Attitudes toward Immigrants: A Natural Experiment.” *American Journal of Sociology* 118(5):1199–1245.
- Leghtas, Izza and David Kitenge. 2022. “What Does Kenya’s New Refugee Act Mean for Economic Inclusion?”. Accessed November 15, 2024.
- URL:** <https://www.refugeesinternational.org/what-does-kenyas-new-refugee-act-mean-for-economic-inclusion/>
- Legrain, Philippe. 2016. Refugees Work: A Humanitarian Investment that Yields Economic Dividends. Technical report Tent Foundation (Tent Partnership for Refugees).
- URL:** https://www.tent.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/05/Tent-Open-RefugeesWork_FINAL – singlepages.pdf
- MacDonald, Mae. 2026. “Aid Cuts and the Politics of Refugee Hosting.” Working paper.
- URL:** https://www.maemacdonald.com/papers/MMacDonald_AidCuts.pdf
- Marbach, Moritz, Jens Hainmueller and Dominik Hangartner. 2018. “The Long-Term Impact of Employment Bans on the Economic Integration of Refugees.” *Science Advances* 4(9):aap9519.
- Maystadt, Jean-François and Gilles Duranton. 2019. “The development push of refugees: Evidence from Tanzania.” *Journal of Economic Geography* 19(2):299–334.
- Miliband, David. 2019. “A Battle Plan for the World Bank.” *Foreign Affairs* .
- URL:** <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/2019-02-19/battle-plan-world-bank>
- Muhumad, Abdirahman A. and Rose Jaji. 2023. “Somali Refugees, Informality, and Self-initiative at Local Integration in Ethiopia and Kenya.” *Journal on Migration and Human Security* 11(1):75–88.
- URL:** <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/23315024231156390>
- Murunga, Godwin R. 2009. Refugees at Home? Coping with Somalia Conflict in Nairobi, Kenya. In *African Studies in Geography from Below*, ed. Michel Ben Arrous and Lazare Ki-Zerbo. Dakar, Senegal: CODESRIA pp. 198–232.
- URL:** <https://publication.codesria.org/index.php/pub/catalog/view/140/1054/3358>
- Nasubo, Fred and Matai Muon. 2024. “The Shirika Plan: In Search of Durable Futures for Refugees in Kenya.” *The Elephant* . Accessed November 11, 2024.

URL: <https://www.theelephant.info/analysis/2024/09/26/the-shirika-plan-in-search-of-durable-futures-for-refugees-in-kenya/>

Nation Media Group. 2025. “Probe Talk about Using Refugees to Rig Elections.”. Accessed 2025-10-15.

URL: <https://nation.africa/kenya/blogs-opinion/editorials/probe-talk-about-using-refugees-to-rig-elections-5229160>

Nyamori, Victor. 2024. “What’s Unsaid: Kenya’s New Integration Plan for Refugees.”. Accessed November 14, 2024.

URL: <https://www.thenewhumanitarian.org/podcasts/2024/03/07/whats-unsaid-kenya-new-integration-plan-for-refugees>

Oliver, Marcia L and Philip J Boyle. 2019. “In and beyond the camp: The rise of resilience in refugee governance.” *Oñati Socio-Legal Series, Forthcoming* .

Opanda, Christine. 2025. Accessed: April 4, 2025.

URL: <https://www.kenyans.co.ke/news/110468-uda-mp-rejects-rutos-plan-integrate-refugees-under-shirika-plan>

Otunnu, Ogenga. 1992. “Factors Affecting the Treatment of Kenyan-Somalis and Somali Refugees in Kenya: A Historical Overview.” *Refuge* 12(5):21–26.

URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/45412094>

Porter, Gina, Kate Hampshire, Peter Kyei, Michael Adjaloo, George Rapoo and Kate Kilpatrick. 2008. “Linkages between livelihood opportunities and refugee–host relations: learning from the experiences of Liberian camp-based refugees in Ghana.” *Journal of refugee studies* 21(2):230–252.

RCK. 2024. Kakuma Conflict Analysis. Technical report Refugee Consortium of Kenya (RCK) Nairobi: .

URL: https://www.rckkenya.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/08/202403RCK_KakumaConflictAnalysis_R1.pdf

Rozo, Sandra V. and Juan F. Vargas. 2021. “Brothers or Invaders? How Crisis-Driven Migrants Shape Voting Behavior.” *Journal of Development Economics* 150:102636.

URL: <https://ideas.repec.org/a/eee/deveco/v150y2021ics0304387821000158.html>

Sakamoto, Maiko, S.M. Asik Ullah and Masakazu Tani. 2024. “Impacts of refugee influx on the local economy and environmental degradation in Bangladesh: A spatial multilevel autoregressive analysis.” *World Development* 165:106233.

URL: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0305750X24001992>

Salehyan, Idean and Kristian Skrede Gleditsch. 2006. “Refugees and the spread of civil war.” *International organization* 60(2):335–366.

Sanghi, Apurva, Harun Onder and Varalakshmi Vemuru. 2016. “Yes” in My Backyard? The Economics of Refugees and Their Social Dynamics in Kakuma, Kenya. Technical report World Bank Washington, DC: .

URL: <https://documents1.worldbank.org/curated/en/308011482417763778/>

[pdf/111303-WP-Kakuma-Report-Yes-in-my-backyard-December-2016-PUBLIC.pdf](#)

- Savun, Burcu and Christian Gineste. 2019. "From Protection to Persecution: Threat Environment and Refugee Scapegoating." *Journal of Peace Research* 56(1):88–102.
URL: <https://doi.org/10.1177/0022343318811432>
- Shahow, Abdullahi Abdille. 2021. "Dadaab: Playing Politics with the Lives of Somali Refugees in Kenya." *The Elephant* . Accessed November 11, 2024.
URL: <https://www.theelephant.info/analysis/2021/10/16/dadaab-playing-politics-with-the-lives-of-somali-refugees-in-kenya/>
- Sheikh, Salah Abdi. 2021. "From Shifta to Terrorist: A Shifting Narrative of Northern Kenya." *The Elephant* .
URL: <https://www.theelephant.info/analysis/2021/06/14/from-shifta-to-terrorist-a-shifting-narrative-of-northern-kenya/>
- Simpson, Gerry and Adrianne Lapar. 2013. "'You are all terrorists' Kenyan police abuse of refugees in Nairobi." *Human Rights Watch* . Accessed 14 November 2024.
URL: <https://www.hrw.org/report/2013/05/29/you-are-all-terrorists/kenyan-police-abuse-refugees-nairobi>
- Steinmayr, Andreas. 2016. "Exposure to Refugees and Voting for the Far-Right: (Unexpected) Results from Austria." .
URL: <https://www.iza.org/publications/dp/9790/exposure-to-refugees-and-voting-for-the-far-right-unexpected-results-from-austria>
- Teferra, Gerawork. 2022. "Kakuma Refugee Camp: Pseudopermanence in Permanent Transience." *Africa Today* 69(1-2):162–189. Accessed November 14, 2024.
URL: <https://muse.jhu.edu/article/864873>
- Turkoglu, Oguzhan. 2026. "Security concerns, ethnic relations, and attitudes toward refugees: evidence from Turkey." *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies* 52(3):686–710.
- UNHCR. 2009. "UNHCR Policy on Refugee Protection and Solutions in Urban Areas." *International Journal of Refugee Law* 21(4):823–850.
URL: <https://academic.oup.com/ijrl/article-abstract/21/4/823/1529906>
- UNHCR. 2014. Policy on Alternatives to Camps. Technical Report UNHCR/HCP/2014/9 United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR).
URL: <https://www.unhcr.org/sites/default/files/legacy-pdf/5422b8f09.pdf>
- UNHCR. 2019. "Refugee Livelihoods and Economic Inclusion: 2019-2023 Global Strategy Concept Note." . Accessed: 2024-12-24.
URL: <https://www.unhcr.org/media/refugee-livelihoods-and-economic-inclusion-2019-2023-global-strategy-concept-note>
- UNHCR. 2021. Global Compact on Refugees: Indicator Report 2021. Technical report United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR). Produced by UNHCR, 16 November 2021.

- URL:** https://www.unhcr.org/global-compact-refugees-indicator-report/wp-content/uploads/sites/143/2021/11/2021_GCR – Indicator – Report_spread_web.pdf
- UNHCR. 2024. “Global Trends Report: Forced Displacement in 2023.” *Geneva: United Nations*.
- UNHCR. 2025a. Global Trends: Forced Displacement in 2024. Technical report United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees Geneva: . Accessed 2025-09-30.
URL: <https://www.unhcr.org/media/global-trends-2024-report>
- UNHCR. 2025b. “Kenya Operational Data Portal.”
URL: <https://data.unhcr.org/en/country/KEN/796>
- UNHCR. 2025c. “UNHCR’s Grandi: critical funding gap may force deeper cuts to refugee aid.”
URL: <https://www.unhcr.org/us/news/stories/unhcr-s-grandi-critical-funding-gap-may-force-deeper-cuts-refugee-aid>
- UNHCR. 2026a. Global Trends: Forced Displacement in 2024. Technical report United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees Geneva: . Accessed 2026-07-30.
URL: <https://www.unhcr.org/media/global-trends-2025-report>
- UNHCR. 2026b. “Operational Data Portal: Refugee Situations.” <https://data.unhcr.org>. Accessed July 2026.
- United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees. 2023. Kenya Operational Update: September 2023. Technical report United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees.
URL: <https://www.unhcr.org/ke/media/kenya-operational-update-september-2023-pdf>
- Valentino, Nicholas A, Stuart N Soroka, Shanto Iyengar, Toril Aalberg, Raymond Duch, Marta Fraile, Kyu S Hahn, Kasper M Hansen, Allison Harell, Marc Helbling et al. 2019. “Economic and cultural drivers of immigrant support worldwide.” *British Journal of Political Science* 49(4):1201–1226.
- Venui, Foni Joyce and Buhendwa Iragi. 2023. “Refugees’ Access to Work Permits.” *Refugee Led Research Hub*. Accessed November 14, 2024.
URL: <https://refugeeledresearch.org/refugees-access-to-work-permits/>
- Verme, Paolo and Kirsten Schuettler. 2021. “The impact of forced displacement on host communities: A review of the empirical literature in economics.” *Journal of Development Economics* 150:102606.
- Vlaev, Ivo. 2012. “How different are real and hypothetical decisions? Overestimation, contrast and assimilation in social interaction.” *Journal of Economic Psychology* 33(5):963–971.
URL: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0167487012000645>
- Weber, Sigrid, Nik Stoop, Peter Van der Windt and Haoyu Zhai. 2025. “A meta-analysis of attitudes towards migrants and displaced persons.” *British Journal of Political Science* 55:e168.

- World Bank and UNHCR. 2021. Understanding the Socioeconomic Conditions of Refugees in Kenya: Volume B: Kakuma Camp. Results from the 2019 Kakuma Socioeconomic Survey. Technical report World Bank and UNHCR. Accessed November 14, 2024.
URL: <https://documents1.worldbank.org/curated/en/443431613628051180/pdf/Understanding-the-Socio-Economic-Conditions-of-Refugees-in-Kenya-Volume-B-Kakuma-Camp-Results-from-the-2019-Kakuma-Socioeconomic-Survey.pdf>
- Zhou, Yang-Yang. 2024. “Refugee Proximity and Support for Citizenship Exclusion in Africa.” Working paper, July 30, 2024.
URL: <https://osf.io/u9t78/download/?format=pdf>
- Zhou, Yang-Yang and Andrew Shaver. 2021. “Reexamining the effect of refugees on civil conflict: a global subnational analysis.” *American Political Science Review* 115(4):1175–1196.
- Zhou, Yang-Yang, Guy Grossman and Shuning Ge. 2023. “Inclusive refugee-hosting can improve local development and prevent public backlash.” *World Development* 166:106203.
- Zhou, Yang-Yang, Naijia Liu, Shuning Ge and Guy Grossman. 2025. “Liberalizing Refugee Hosting Policies without Losing the Vote.” OSF Preprints, Version 4.
URL: <https://doi.org/10.31219/osf.io/94tpy>